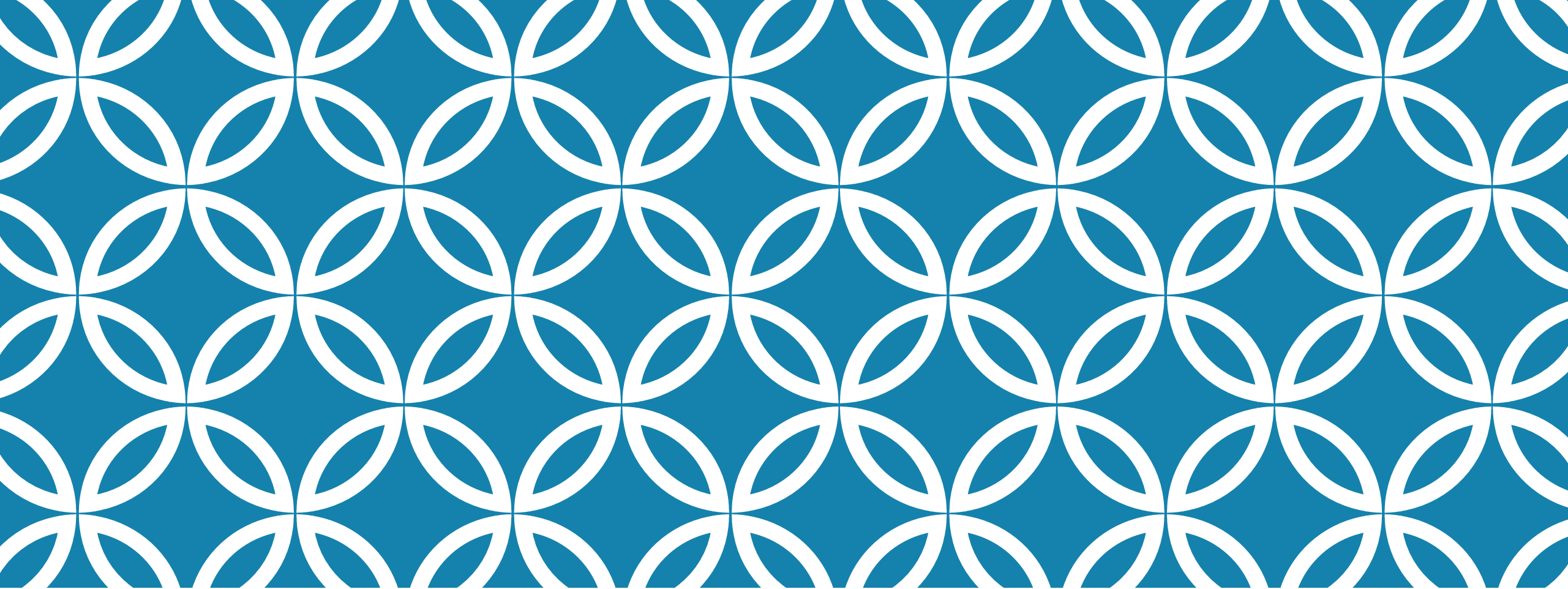




PUBP309: EDUCATION POLICY

School System in Post colonial India

Shivakumar Jolad
FLAME University

Schools in Colonial India -1929

Percentage of primary educational Institutions by management and provinces- 1929

Review by Hartog Committee 1929, (includes Male and Female schools)

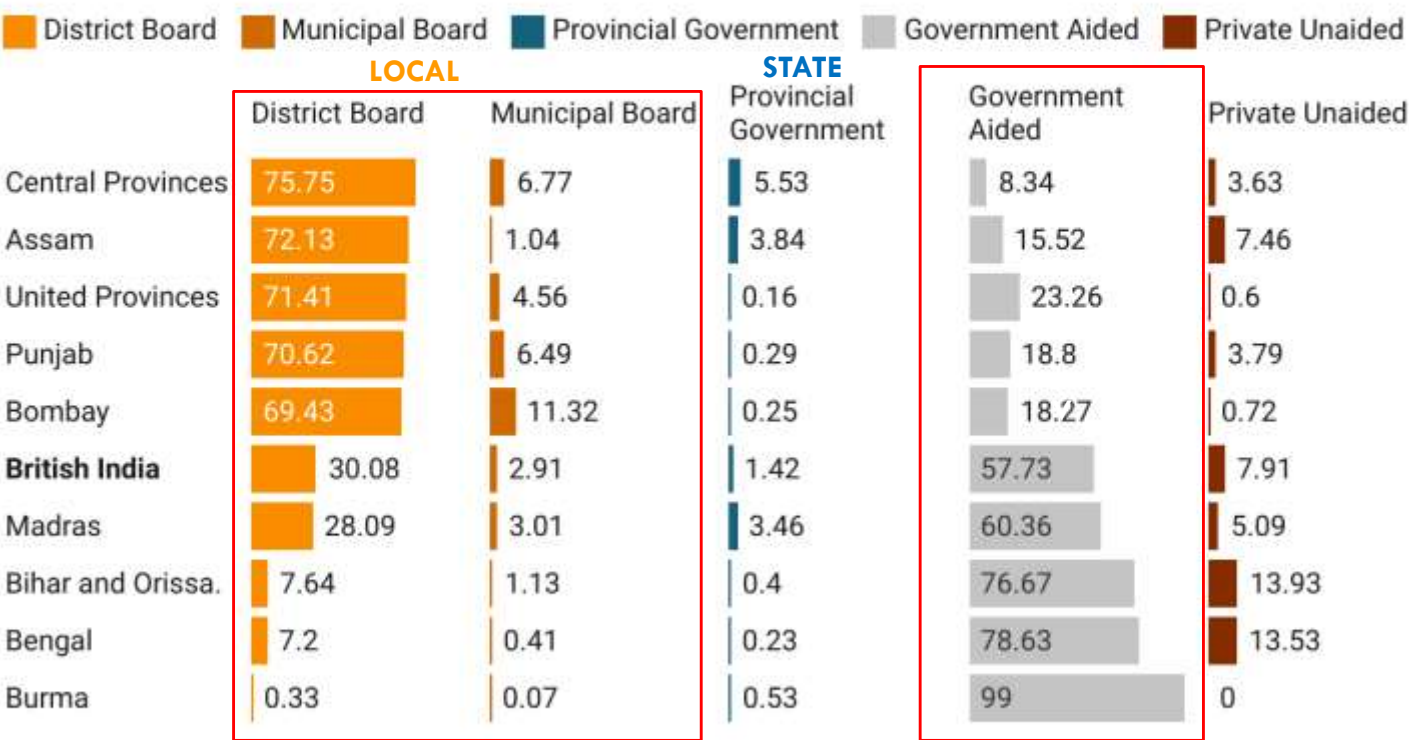


Chart: Shivakumar Jolad • Source: Auxiallry Committee (Education) of the Indian Statutory Commission 1929 • Created with Datawrapper

INTERIM REPORT
of the Indian Statutory Commission.
(Review of Growth of Education in British India by the
Auxiliary Committee appointed by the Commission.)
SEPTEMBER, 1929.



Philip Hartog

Percentage of Schools by Management in different States in India

Based on UDISE 2019-20

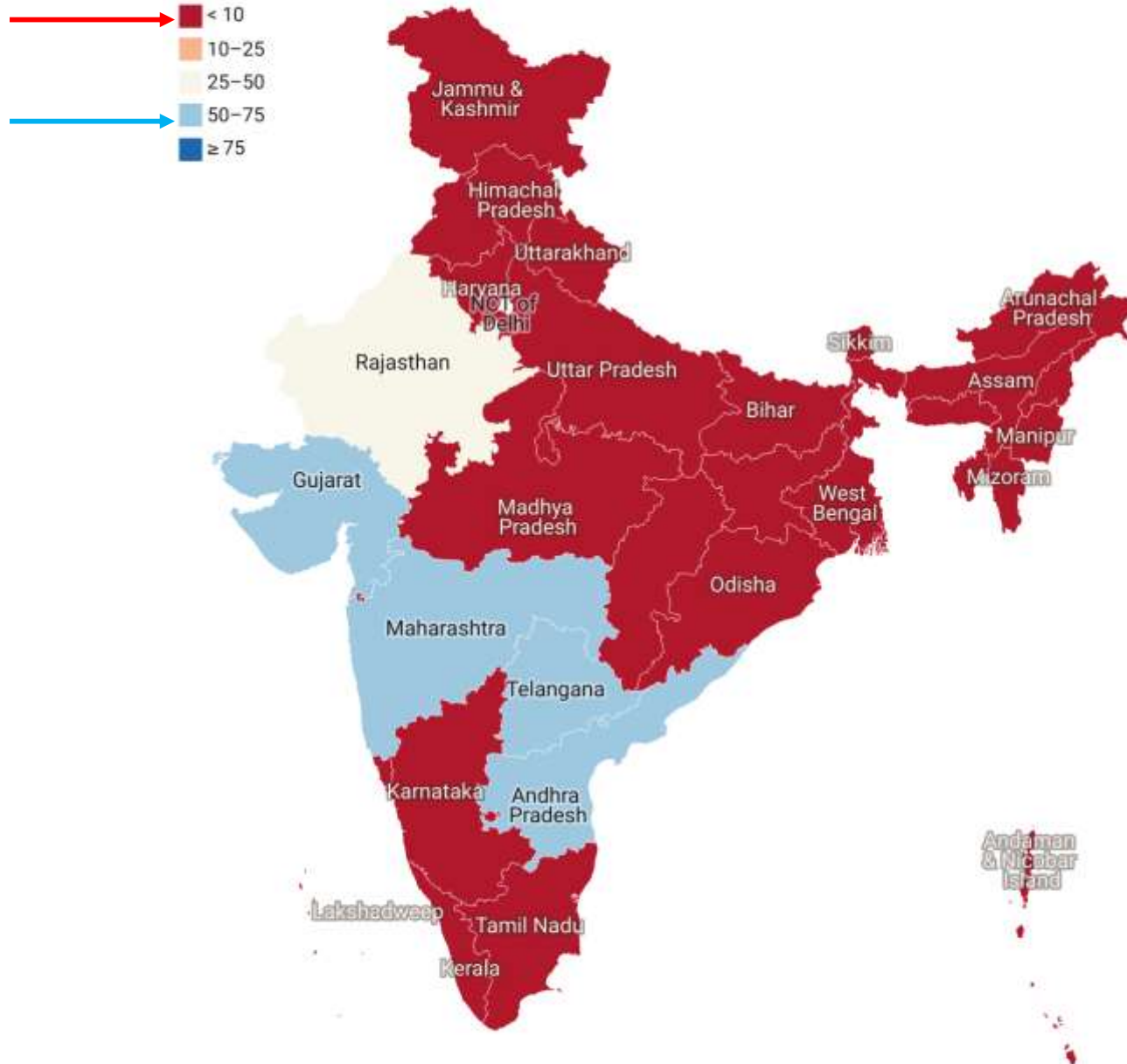
■ Department of Education
 ■ Local body
 ■ Tribal/Social Welfare Department
 ■ Other govt. schools
 ■ Other central govt. schools
 ■ Government Aided
 ■ Private Unaided (Recog/ Unrecog/ Madrassas)



Chart: Khushi Rajpuria and Shivakumar Jolad • Source: UDISE 2019-20 • Created with Datawrapper

Percentage of Local Body Schools in Indian States

Local body schools (%) - based on UDISE 2021-22



State control of school education in colonial and post-colonial India

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Management in Education

1–14

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Research article

First published online September 17, 2024

State control of school education in colonial and post-colonial India

[Shivakumar Jolad](#)   and [Khushi Rajpuria](#) [View all authors and affiliations](#)

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Contents



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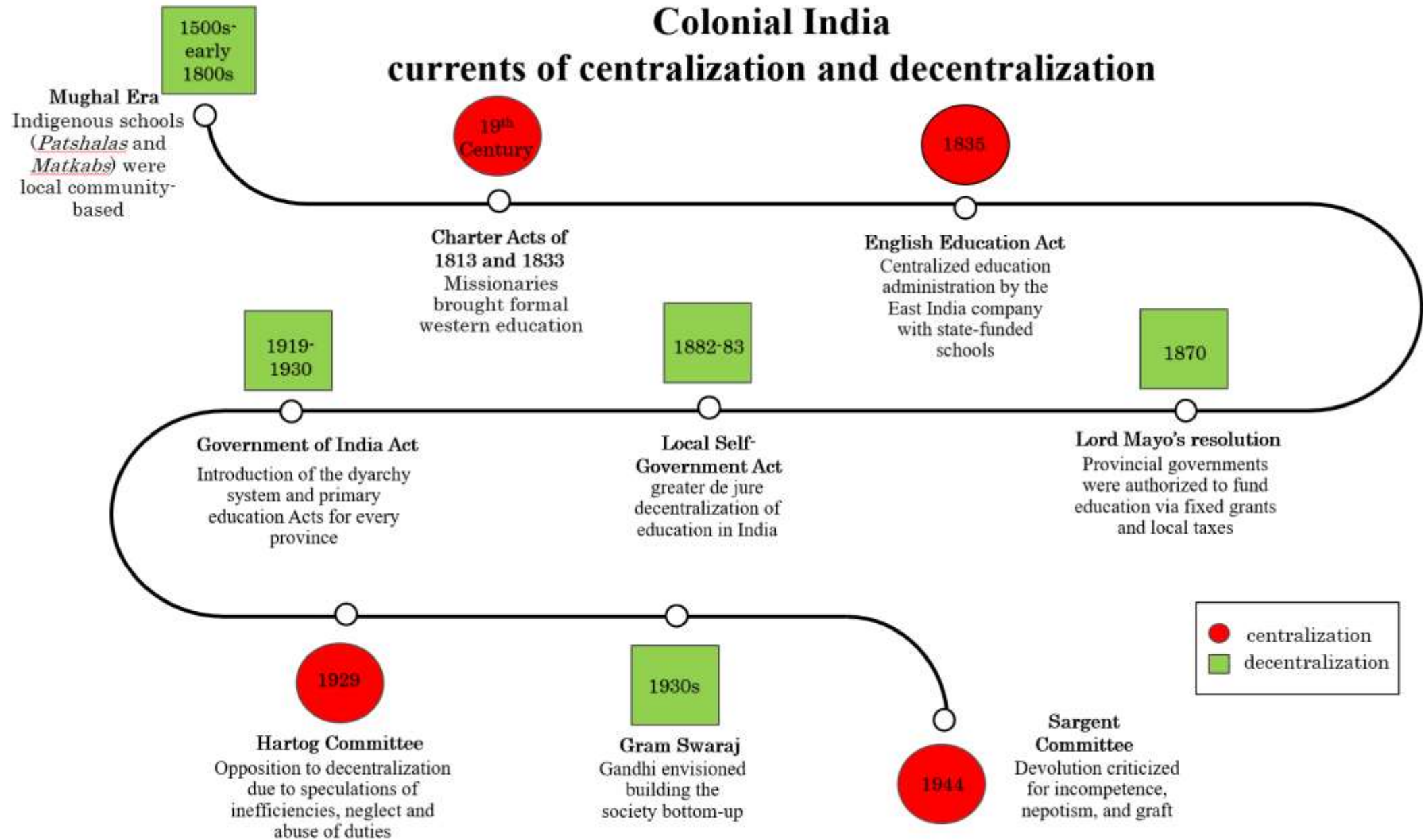
Info

Abstract

Studies have indicated that local governments and communities can play a legitimate role in governing publicly-funded schools, although debates continue in relation to where and how decentralization operates across different contexts. In the Indian context, it has been argued that educational decentralization received a significant boost following the constitutional amendments of 1992, which mandated local government school management in rural and urban areas across India. **However, drawing from the history of school management in India, we show that in colonial India, government-funded schools were locally managed by district boards and municipal bodies. By studying the education Acts of Indian states post-independence, we show that nearly all states adopted a centralized management system with state-controlled appointment and transfer of teachers and funding.** Nationally, about 77% of government schools are managed by the state Department of Education, while only 18% of schools are controlled by local bodies. By analyzing sections of the Right to Education Act of 2009, we show that while the Act advocates for decentralized management of schools, it fails to devolve funds and functionaries to the local level. **We argue that India's constitutional structure, weak fiscal devolution to local bodies, centralized appointment of functionaries, bureaucratic mistrust of local authorities, fear of local elite capture, upper caste control, and teacher union lobbying have led to centralized state control of education.**

Colonial India

currents of centralization and decentralization



STATE EDUCATION ACTS

Maharashtra and Gujarat (which were part of Bombay in 1947-1960) followed a different trajectory. The Bombay Primary Education Act- 1947 (later amended and renamed as Maharashtra Primary Education Act) entrusted the District school boards, Municipalities, and Municipal school boards with powers to establish and manage.

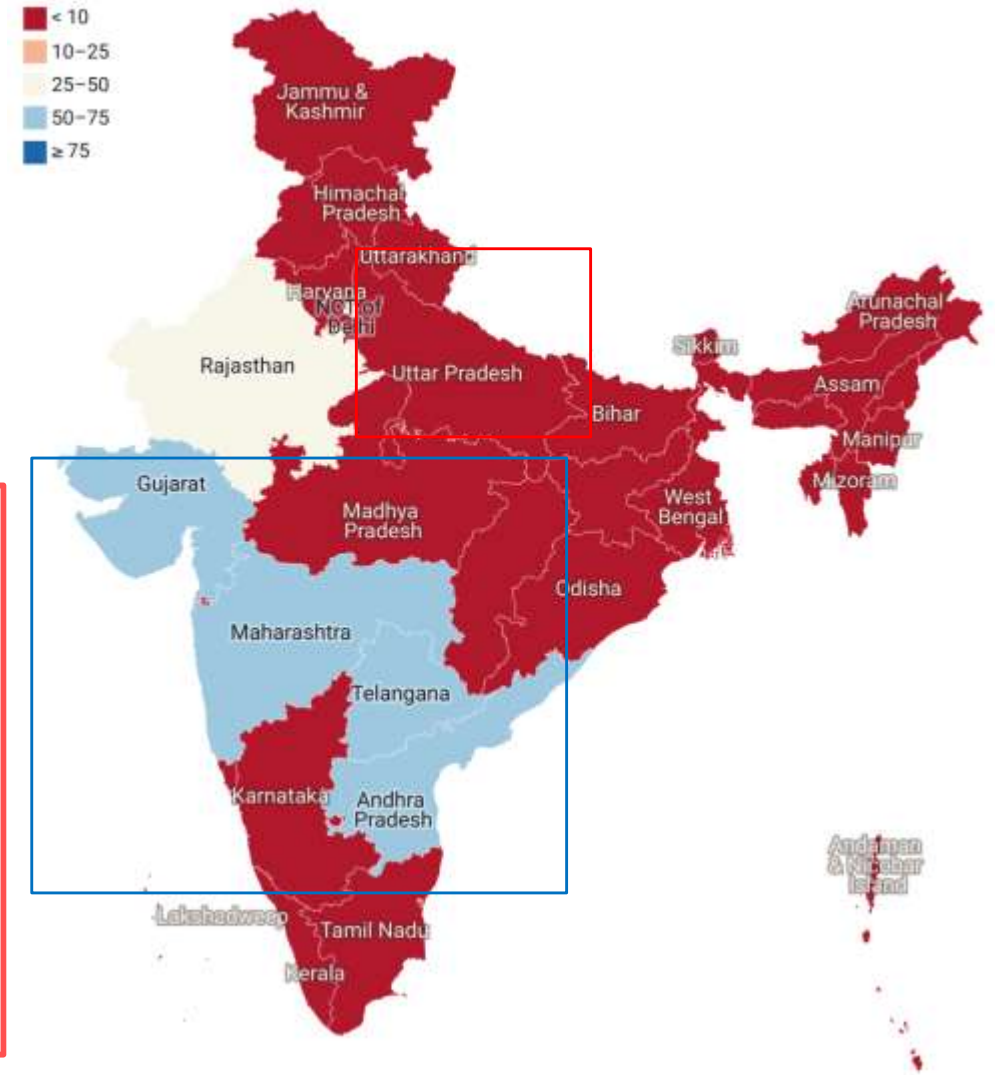
Andhra Pradesh : The Andhra Pradesh Primary Education Act- 1982, vested the power to ensure free and compulsory education to local authorities- (municipal corporation/municipal council, Zilla Praja Parishad, Mandala Praja Parishad).

Karnataka: Karnataka Education Act- 1983 gave sweeping powers to the state to regulate general education including the establishment and recognition of schools, the appointment of teachers in government schools. The state to take over the management, of educational institutions, including local authority schools and private schools, all in “public interest”

Uttar Pradesh: the Basic Education Act of 1972, brought all the local body and/or zilla parishad schools under the state government's direct control, teacher appointment became more centralized, and their salaries were paid by the state government directly

Percentage of Local Body Schools in Indian States

Local body schools (%) - based on UDISE 2021-22



Post-colonial India

currents of centralization and decentralization

Constitution of India

A highly centralised two-tier Federal system was adopted

1950

1951-54

Kher Committee Report

Local administration caused teacher harassment. Safeguards were recommended.

1966

Kothari Commission

Advocated for a greater role of state governments in education governance

1970-1990

State Education Acts

Took control of Education from local bodies. Controls funds and functionaries

1992

NPE & PoA

envisaged district and village-level bodies to plan, implement and administer educational programmes

1992-93

73rd and 74th constitutional amendments

Mandated decentralization criticized for being unsuccessful as PRIs lacked the resources carry out their duties

1984

Planning Commission
Recommended a multi-level planning framework with districts being treated as sub-states

2001

Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan, Central schemes

Funding for Education from Centre- also controls education ; District level Planning Village Edu Committees

2009

RTE Act

Assigns duties to local governments without empowering them. There is limited fiscal transfer

2020

National Education Policy

Silent about PRIs, urban local bodies or educational decentralization

- centralization
- decentralization
- mixed

SCHOOL SYSTEM IN INDIA

A large and complex education system with multiple providers and languages.

Influenced by colonial legacy but has undergone significant transformation since the 1990s.

Education is legally a nonprofit sector, but privatization is challenging this principle.

Post Independence: Lack of standardized education structure across states post-1947.

Key Milestones:

- Kothari Commission (1964-66): Recommended a national education pattern.
- National Policy on Education, 1968: Introduced the 10+2+3 education structure.
- National Policy on Education, 1986 & 1992: Reinforced a national system ensuring equal access to education.

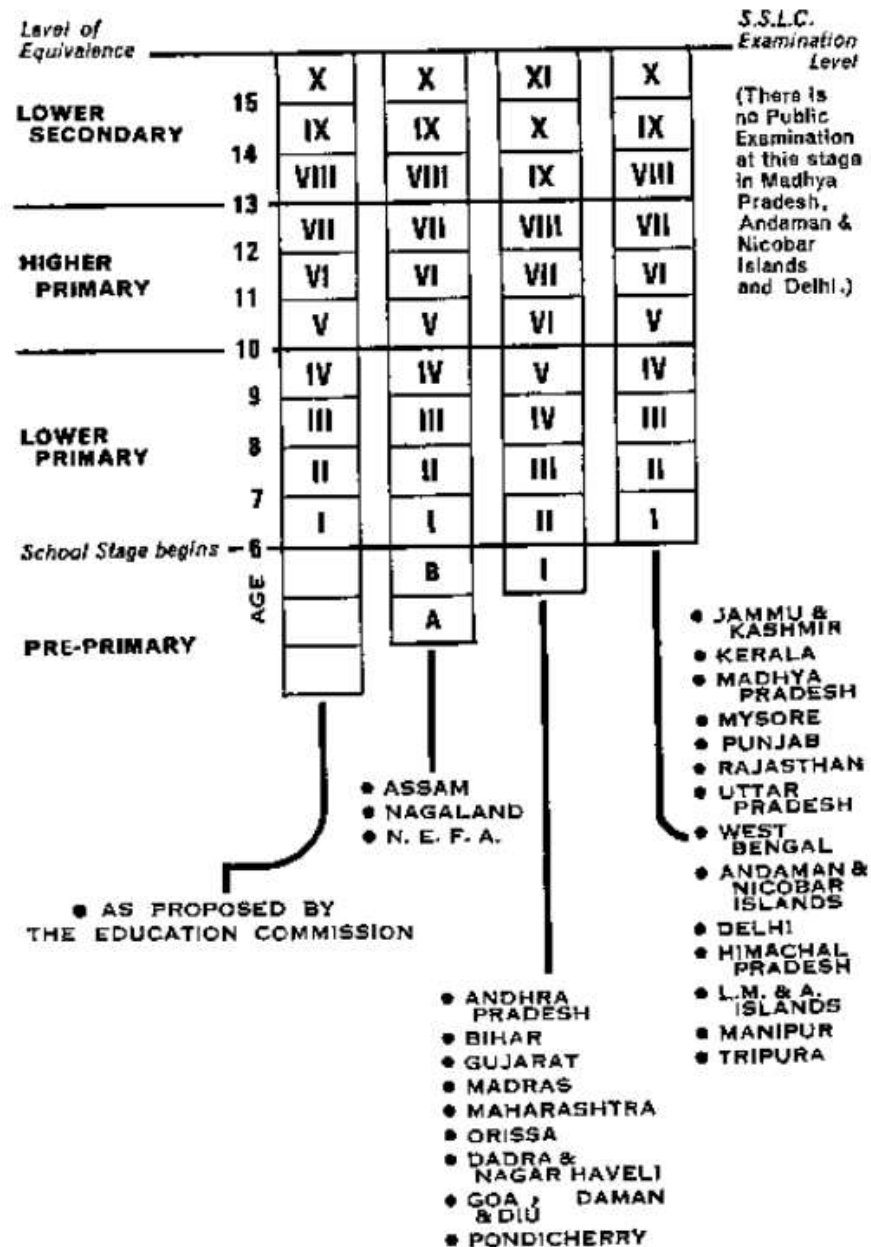


Fig. 3

School System in India in 1966

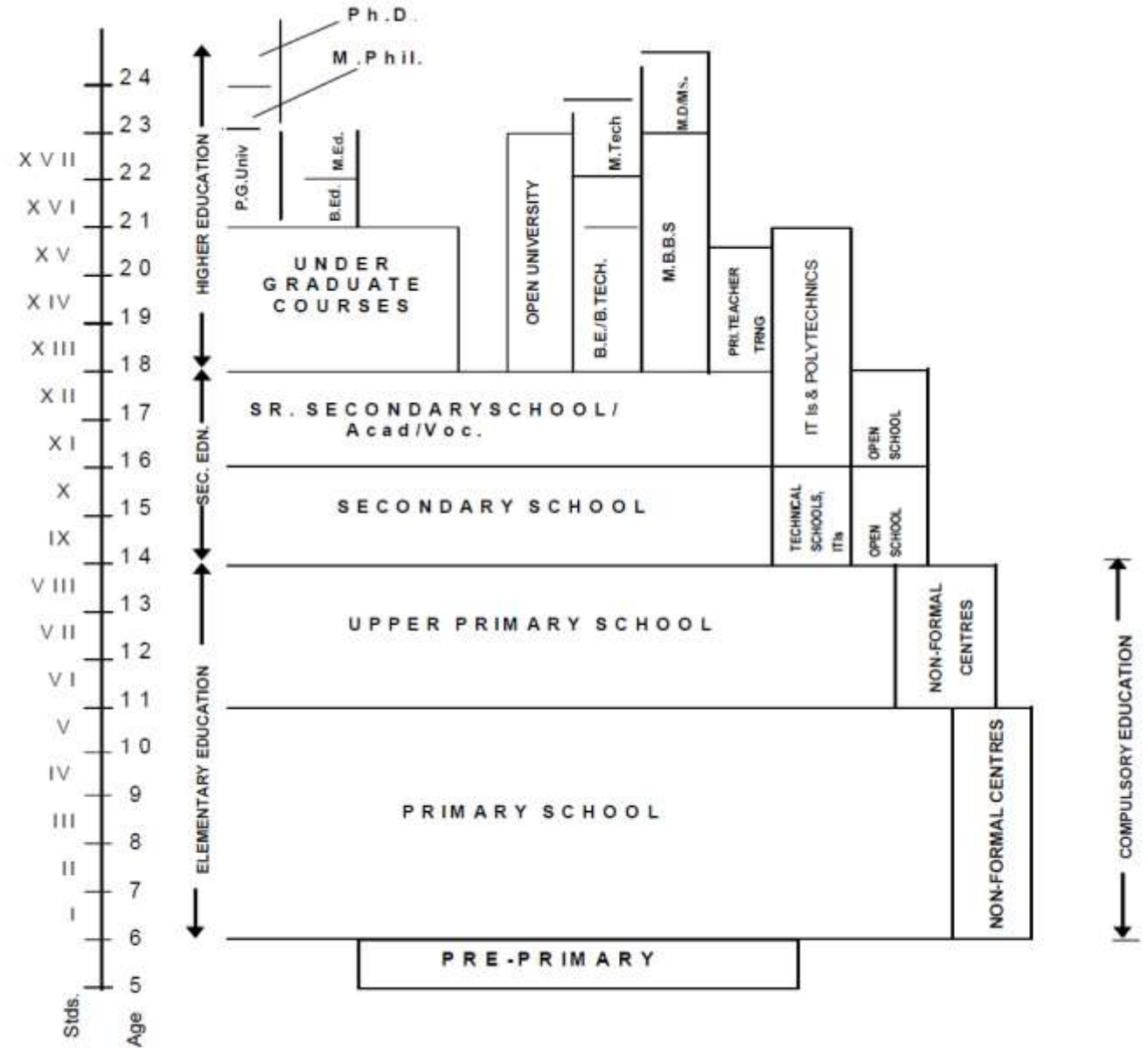
Kothari Commission (1966)

National Policy on Education, 1968, suggested a “uniform educational structure in all parts of the country” through the adoption of a **10+2+3 pattern**. It allowed the higher secondary education comprising the +2 level to be located in either schools or colleges.

The 1968 policy also endorsed the recommendation given by the Commission on establishing a **Common School System for building social cohesion and national integration.**

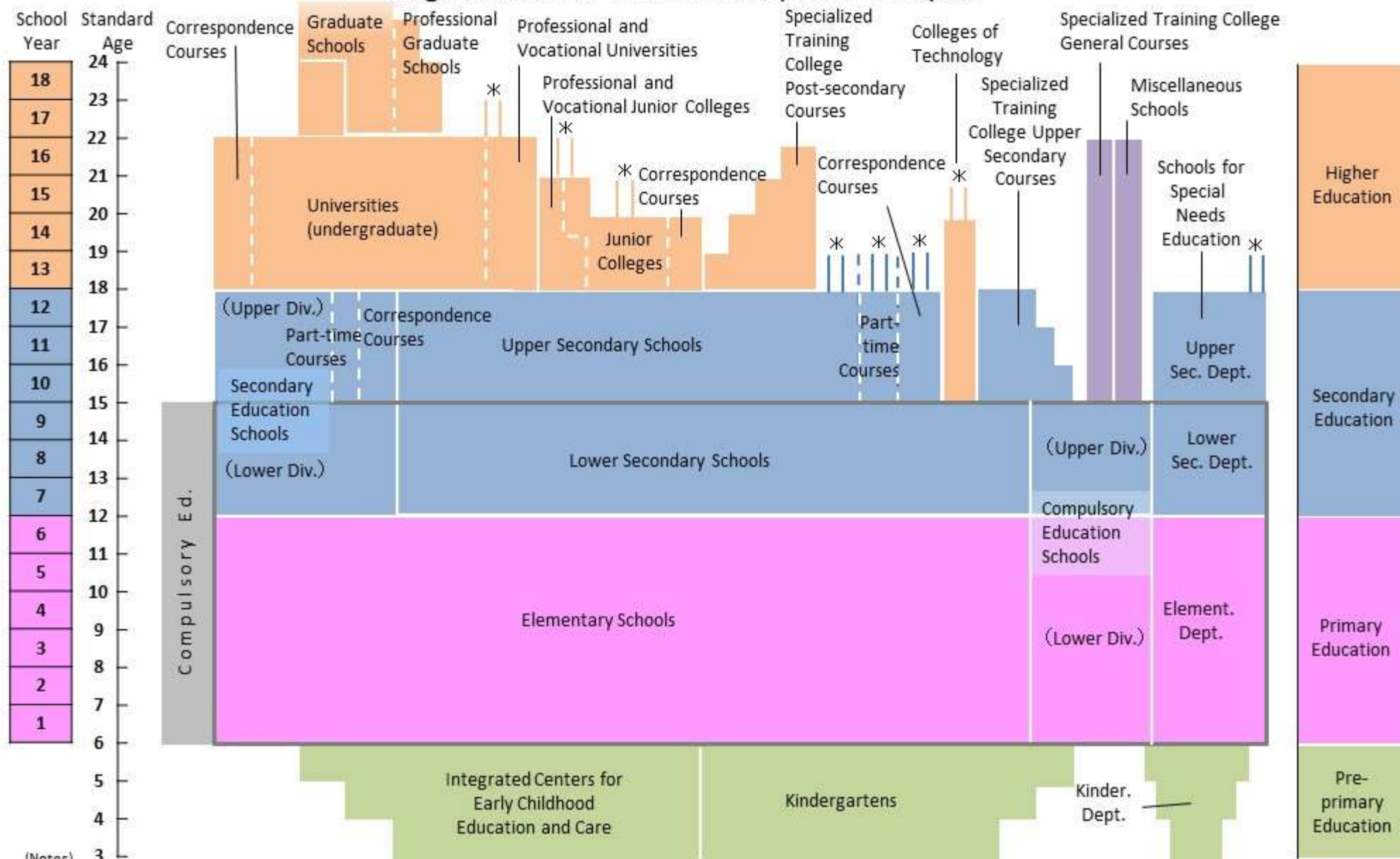
The National Policy on Education, 1986, and subsequently issued revised POA in 1992: This laid down the idea of a national system of education that would provide access to education of a comparable quality, up to a given level, for all children irrespective of their caste, creed, location, or sex, and also emphasized that effective measures be taken to establish a Common School System.

THE STRUCTURE OF THE EDUCATION SYSTEM IN INDIA



Source: NUEPA (2007a)

Organization of the School System in Japan



(Notes)

(1) * indicates advanced courses

(2) Upper secondary schools, upper division of secondary education schools, universities, junior colleges, and upper secondary department of schools for special needs Education can have separate courses with course terms of 1 year or more.

(3) A child aged from 0 to 2 years old can attend Centers for Early Childhood Education and Care because it functions as school as well as child welfare institution.

(4) Age and admission requirements for Specialized Training College General Courses and Miscellaneous Schools are not defined uniformly.

JAPAN

SOME IMPORTANT QUESTIONS IN EDUCATION GOVERNANCE

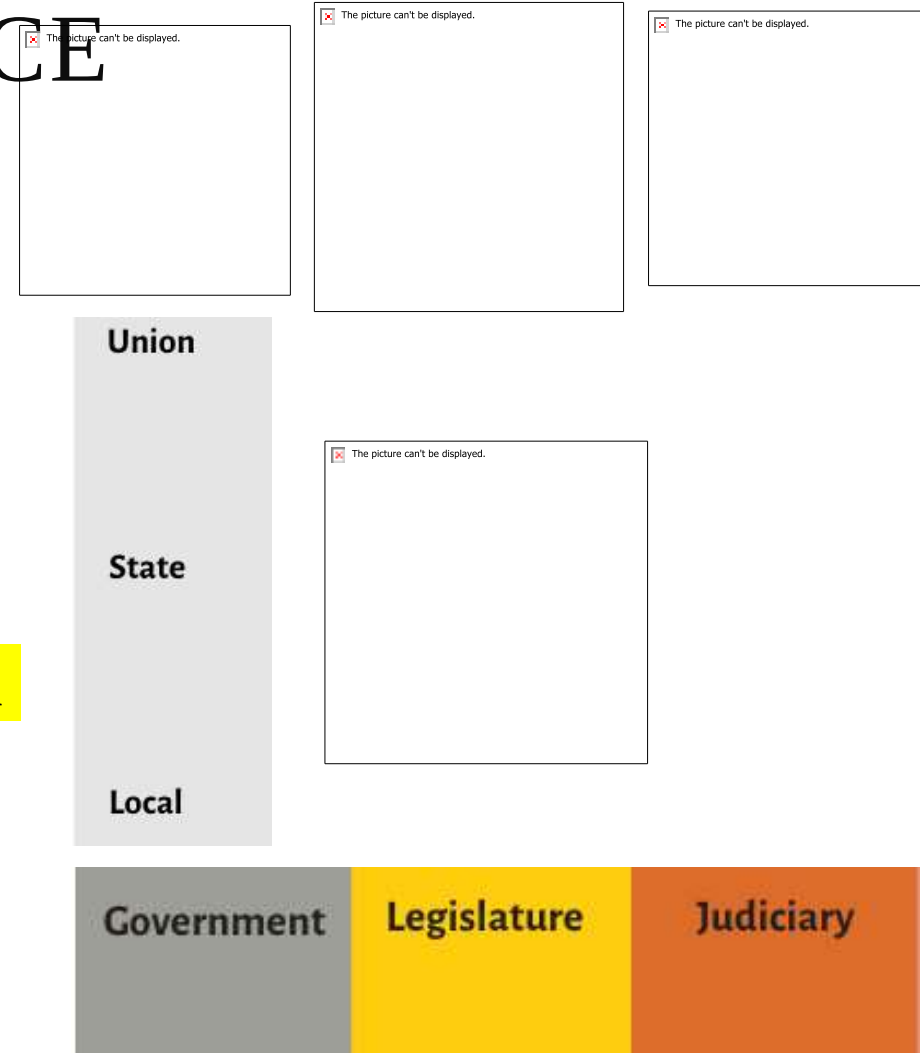
Who ought to control the education system?

Who should manage the schools?

Who should fund the schools and appoint the functionaries (teachers and staff)?

What functions should be decentralized and to what extent?¹

What impact will this decentralization have on teachers, classroom procedures and student performance?²



¹ ZAJDA J, "INTRODUCTION: DECENTRALISATION AND PRIVATISATION IN EDUCATION: THE ROLE OF THE STATE," DECENTRALISATION AND PRIVATISATION IN EDUCATION (2006) SPRINGER, DORDRECHT <[HTTPS://LINK.SPRINGER.COM/CHAPTER/10.1007/978-1-4020-3358-2_1](https://link.springer.com/chapter/10.1007/978-1-4020-3358-2_1)>

² MAJUMDAR M, "DECENTRALISATION REFORMS AND PUBLIC SCHOOLS: A HUMAN DEVELOPMENT PERSPECTIVE" (2002) WORKING PAPER 170 MADRAS INSTITUTE OF DEVELOPMENT STUDIES <[HTTPS://WWW.MIDS.AC.IN/ASSETS/DOC/WP_170.PDF](https://www.mids.ac.in/assets/doc/wp_170.pdf)>
Image: Understanding State Capabilities, Accountability Initiative



Indian School Education- A snapshot



**1.48 million
Schools**



**265 million
Children**



**9.5 million
Teachers**



**Govt Schools
1.02 million**

**Only 12 % total
schools under
local government**



UDISE+

2021-22



Government schools¹² are entirely financed and run by concerned government bodies.

10.9 lakh schools | **13.1** crore students

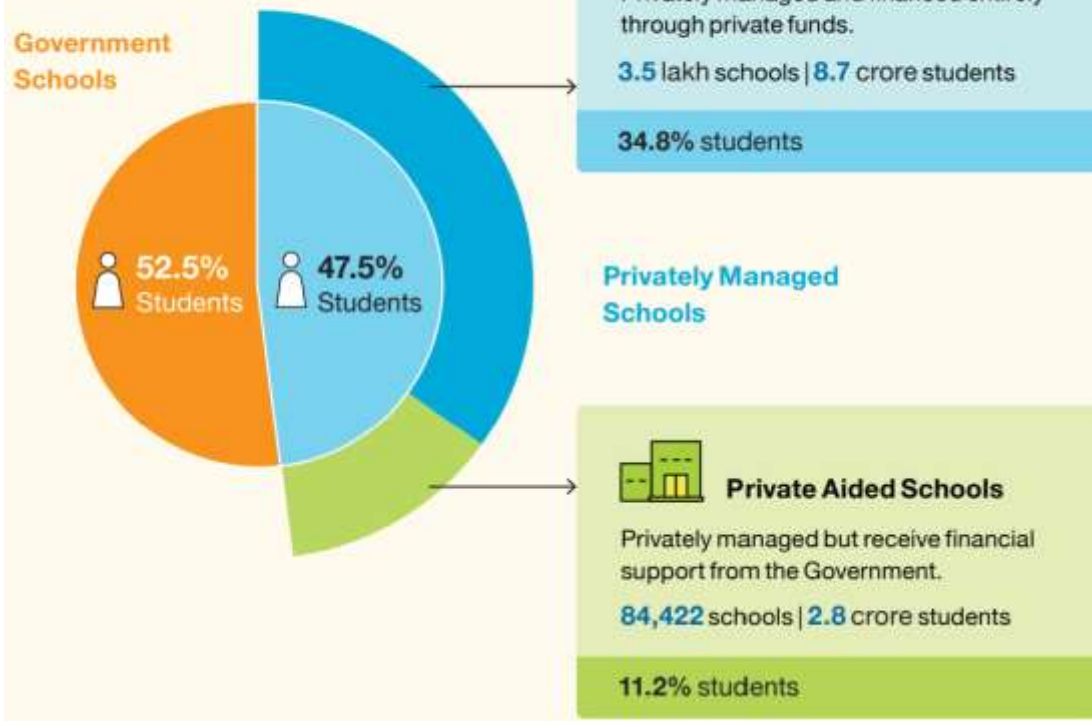


Privately managed¹³ schools are not run by a government body. They may be financed philanthropically, through parent fees or through government aid.

4.6 lakh schools | **11.9** crore students

- Preschool: No fixed duration.
- **Primary (Grades 1–5): 5 years.**
- **Upper Primary (Grades 6–8): 3 years.**
- **High School (Grades 9–10): 2 years.**
- **Higher Secondary (Grades 11–12): 2 years.**

Disparities persist across states in school structuring and implementation.



2022

School Category

P (1-5)

P+UP (1-7 /1-8)

P+UP+SS+HSS (1-12)

UP (6-7/6-8)

UP+SS+HSS (6-12)

P+UP+SS (1-10)

UP+SS (6-10)

SS (7-10/ 8-10)

SS+HSS (8-12/9-12)

HSS (11-12)

Government-Funded and Government-Managed Schools

- **Run by local or state authorities** and funded by the government.
- Provide **free and compulsory education** from Grades 1–8 under the Right to Education (RTE) Act.
- Includes primary, upper primary, secondary, and higher secondary schools.
- Usually have **limited resources, infrastructure, and quality variations** across states.

Government-Funded, Specified Category Schools

- **Established for specific populations or objectives**, often under central government bodies. Admission criteria include **merit, social demographics (tribal students), or gender**.
- Examples:
 - **Navodaya Vidyalayas** – For academically bright rural students.
 - **Kendriya Vidyalayas** – For children of transferable central government employees.
 - **Tribal Welfare Schools** – For children from Scheduled Tribes (STs).
 - **Sainik Schools** – Prepare students for the National Defence Academy.
 - **Central Tibetan Schools** – For Tibetan refugees.
 - **Kasturba Gandhi Balika Vidyalayas** – For girls from disadvantaged backgrounds.

Archana Mehendale and Rahul Mukhopadhyay (2021), *School System and Education Policy in India: Charting the Contours*, in P. M. Sarangapani, R. Pappu (eds.), *Handbook of Education Systems in South Asia*, Global Education Systems, https://doi.org/10.1007/978-981-15-0032-9_13

Government-Funded, Privately Managed Schools

- Schools receive **state or central government grants**, but are **run by private entities**.

- Includes:

- **Grant-in-Aid Schools** – Private schools that receive government financial aid.
- **Madrasas (Islamic Schools)** – Some receive government funding, others are independent.
- **Special Training Centers & Bridge Schools** – Provide education for out-of-school children to help them transition into formal schooling.
- **Model Schools/Public-Private Partnership (PPP) Schools** – Established with **private entities and NGOs** to expand quality education.

Privately Managed Schools for Specific Groups

- **Run by NGOs and charities** to serve marginalized and special-needs students.

- Includes:

- **Schools for children with disabilities** – Provide specialized learning environments.
- **Schools for migrant children, street children, and working children** – Often run by NGOs.
- **Alternate Education Schools** – Use non-traditional methods to cater to diverse learning needs.

Privately Funded and Privately Managed Schools

- **Privately owned and financed**, without government support.
- Vary **widely in fees and quality**, ranging from **elite international schools** to **low-fee private schools**.
- Admission policies depend on **family background, ability to pay, and entrance exams**.
- Many are **English-medium schools**, attracting middle-class and urban students.

Privately Managed Minority Schools (Religious & Linguistic Minority Schools)

- Recognized under **Articles 29 & 30 of the Indian Constitution**, allowing minorities to establish and administer their institutions.
- Include **Christian missionary schools, Madrasas, and linguistic minority schools**.
- Government cannot interfere with administration, but they must meet basic education standards.
- Many receive state funding but operate independently in terms of admissions and curriculum choices.

Table 2 Types of schools

Government funded			Privately funded and privately managed		
Government managed (open to all) (1)	Government managed (specified category) (2)	Privately managed (3)	Secular (4)	Minority schools (5)	For specific groups (6)
Run by local authorities and state government available at habitation level	Run by central or state government and for a specific population (tribal welfare schools, Navodaya Vidyalaya, Kendriya Vidyalaya, Central Tibetan Schools, Sainik Schools, Kasturba Gandhi Balika Vidyalaya, Sanskrit Pathshala)	Grant-in-aid schools Bridge schools/special Training Special schools Madrasa Model Schools/PPP schools	Private schools	Religious minority schools Linguistic minority schools	Special schools for children with disabilities Alternate schools run by nongovernmental organizations for street children, migrants

Archana Mehendale and Rahul Mukhopadhyay (2021), *School System and Education Policy in India: Charting the Contours*, in P. M. Sarangapani, R. Pappu (eds.), *Handbook of Education Systems in South Asia*, Global Education Systems, https://doi.org/10.1007/978-981-15-0032-9_13

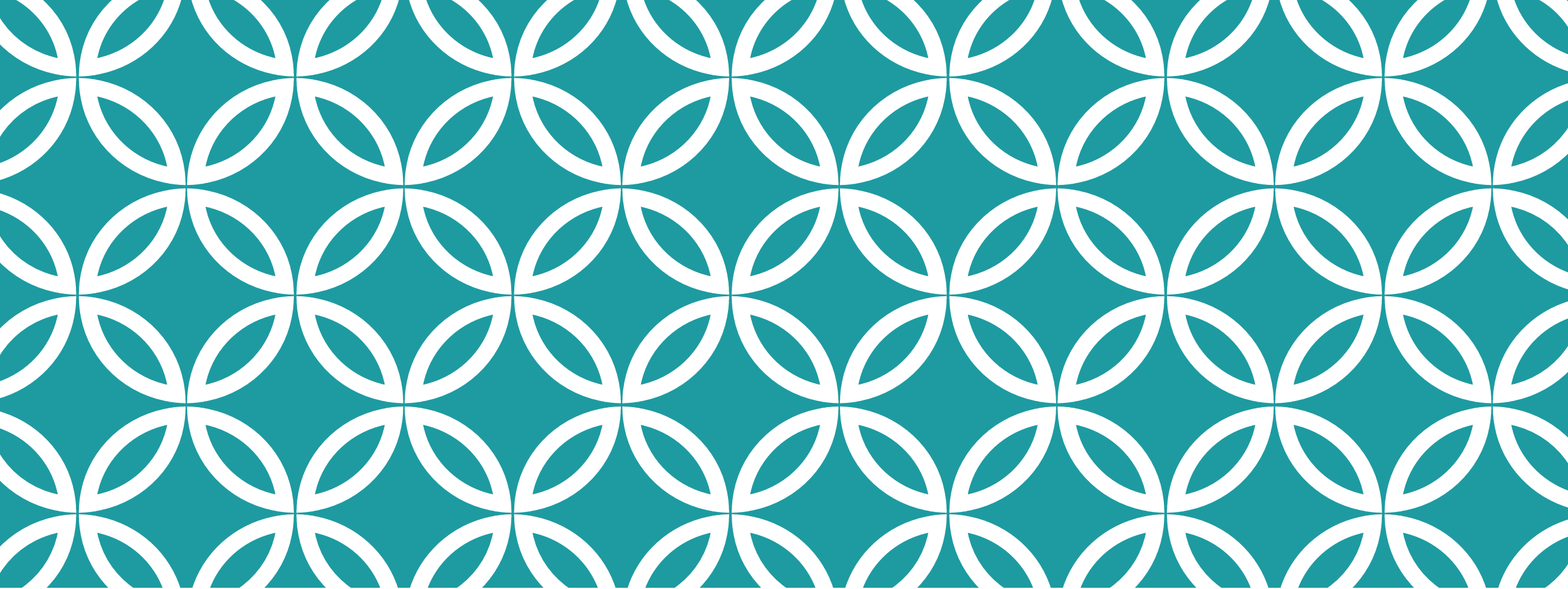
ROLE OF STATE

Table 3 Structures governing school education

Level	Political	Administrative	Academic	Examination boards
Central	Government of India	Department of School Education and Literacy, Ministry of Human Resource Department	National Council for Education, Research and Training (NCERT), National Institute for Education Planning and Administration (NIEPA), National Council for Teacher Education (NCTE)	Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE), Council for the Indian School Certificate Examination (CISCE) (private board conducting ICSE exams), National Institute of Open Schooling (NIOS)
State	State government	Department of Public Instruction/Directorate of School Education/Education Department	State Council of Education, Research and Training (SCERT), State Institute of Educational Management and Training (SIEMAT)	State Boards of Examination, State Boards of Open School, State Madrasa Boards, State Sanskrit Education Board
Local	Zila Panchayat/Parishad/urban local bodies	District Education Office	District Institute for Education and Training (DIET), Colleges of Teacher Education (CTEs), and Institutes of Advanced Studies in Education (IASEs)	
Block or Mandal	Panchayat Samiti/Mandal Panchayat	Block/Mandal Education Office/School Inspectorate	Block Resource Centre (BRC) and Cluster Resource Centre (CRC)	
Village/city/town	Gram Panchayat (rural areas) Zones/wards and councilors (urban areas)	Village Education Committee and Head Master Education Committees and Ward Committees	Teachers	

Adapted from Ramachandran (2009, p. 143)

Note: Specific nomenclature of institutions could vary across states



GOVERNMENT SCHOOLS IN INDIA



PMC School, Kothrud



Zilla Parishad School, Shirur, Pune





Assam Government school, Majuli
Island District



Karnataka Department of
education School,
Chamarajanagar





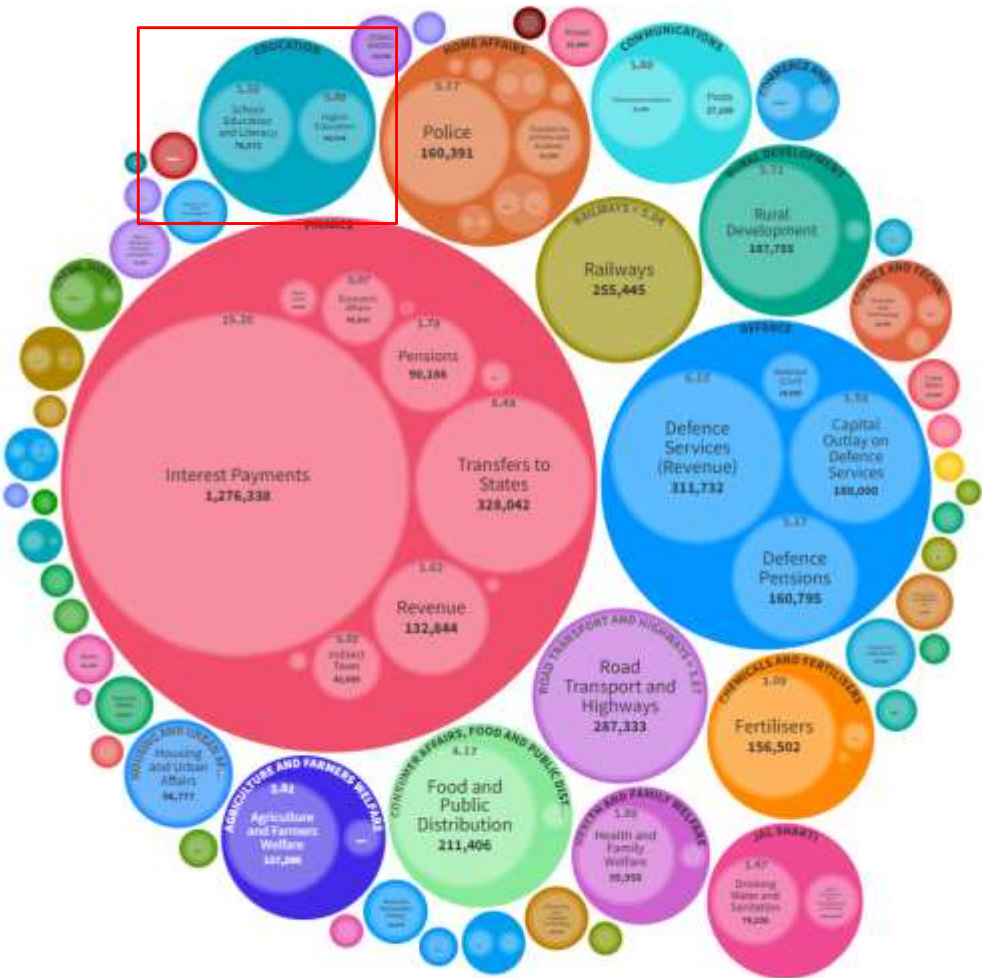
नवोदय विद्यालय समिति

Navodaya Vidyalaya Samiti

(An Autonomous Body Under Ministry of Education) Government Of India







BUDGET 2024-25 ALLOCATIONS

Union Budget 2024-25- School Education (₹ crores)

Comparison of sectoral allocation under Department of School Education and Literacy (Ministry of Education) between 2024-25 and 2025-26 budgets

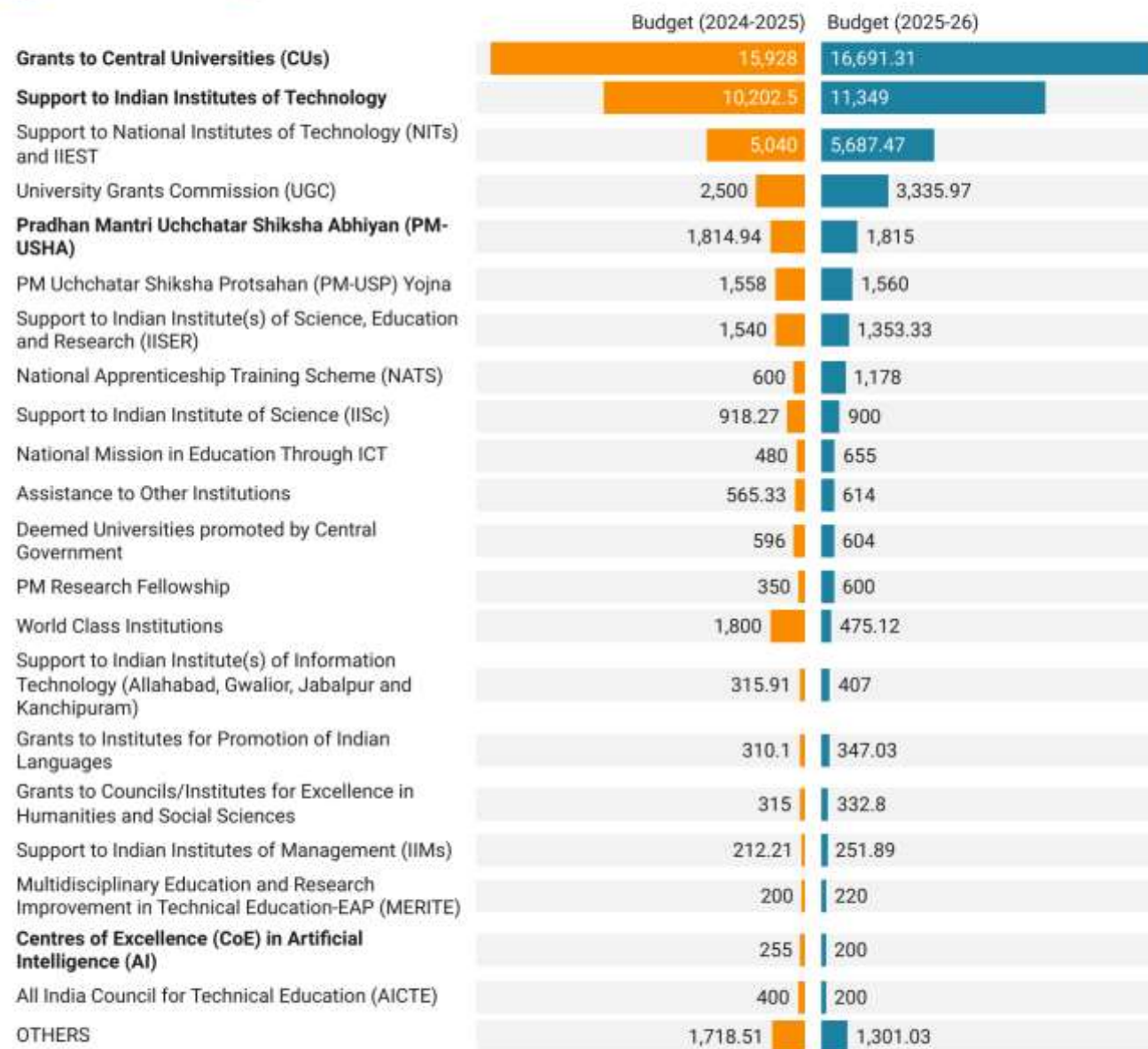
	Budget-2024-2025	Budget- 2025-2026
Samagra Shiksha	37,010	41,250
Pradhan Mantri Poshan Shakti Nirman (PM POSHAN)	12,467.39	12,500
Kendriya Vidyalaya Sangathan (KVS)	9,302.67	9,503.84
PM Schools for Rising India (PM SHRI)	6,050	7,500
Navodaya Vidyalaya Samiti (NVS)	5,800	5,305.23
Strengthening Teaching-Learning and Results for States (STARS)	1,250	1,250
National Council of Educational Research and Training (NCERT)	510	593.71
National Means cum Merit Scholarship Scheme	377	374
New India Literacy Programme (NILP)	160	160
Pradhan Mantri Innovative Learning Programme (DHRUV)	0.01	55
Secretariat	55.02	52.51
National Bal Bhawan	26	27.8
Directorate of Adult Education	0.01	0.01

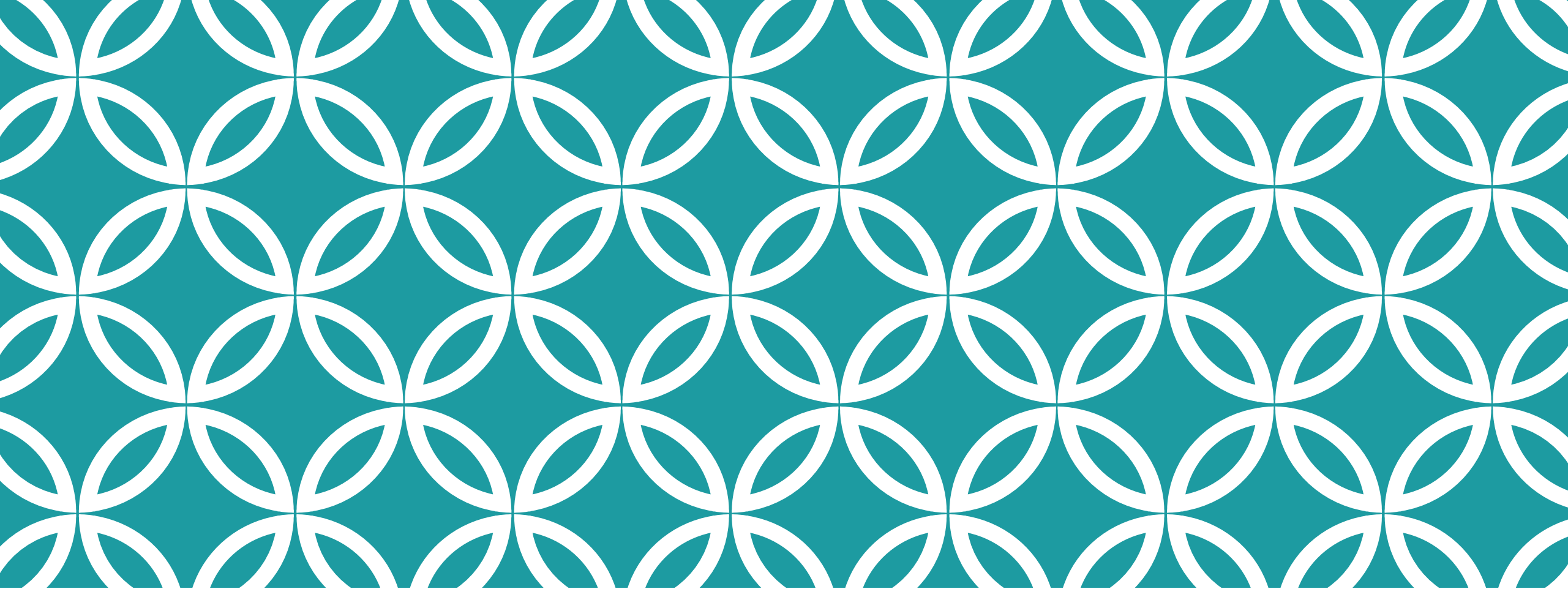
Chart: Shivakumar Jolad • Source: <https://www.indiabudget.gov.in/> • Created with Datawrapper

Union Budget 2025-26 Higher education sectoral allocation

Comparison of sectoral allocation to higher education 2024-25 and 2025-26 Union budgets - (₹ crores)

■ Budget (2024-2025)
 ■ Budget (2025-26)





SMALL SCHOOLS



Efficient Resourcing and Effective Governance through School Complexes

Objective: Schools are grouped into school complexes to facilitate the sharing of resources and render school governance more local, effective, and efficient.

Achievements and challenges related to the expansion of the Indian schooling system

India now has near universal enrolment of children in primary schools. Gender parity has been achieved and the most disadvantaged groups have access to primary schools. These are laudable achievements, and must be acknowledged as such, while the task may be unfinished.

All this has been enabled by expansion of the elementary schooling system, notably by the establishment of primary schools in every habitation across the country, driven by the Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan (SSA), and other efforts across the States. While the basic principle of the expansion of the schooling system, of having a primary school within 1 km of each habitation, has enabled access, it has led to certain significant issues and challenges.

According to U-DISE 2016-17 data, nearly 28% of India's public primary schools and 14.8% of India's upper primary schools have less than 30 students. The average number of students per grade in the elementary schooling system (primary and upper primary, i.e. Grades 1-8) is about 14, with a notable proportion even below 6; during the year 2016-17, there were 119,303 single-teacher schools, the majority of them (94,028) being primary schools serving Grades 1-5.

In essence: our strategy of school expansion has delivered access, but has resulted in the development of very small schools, i.e., schools with small number of students. This is now a structural matter of our schooling system and underlies some key issues that are serious challenges to improving the quality of education. There are three kinds of serious challenges, and other relatively smaller ones.

First, the small size of schools makes it economically suboptimal and operationally complex, to allocate and deploy all the resources necessary to run a good school. Most importantly, this affects the deployment of teachers and availability of critical physical resources. Some of the most serious manifestations and implications of this matter are:

- Teachers have to teach multiple grades at the same time (called "multigrade teaching"). While there are many occasions where varied age groups learning together is very useful, a structural constraint of this sort, where multigrade teaching is the default, is deeply detrimental to educational quality.
- Teachers have to teach many subjects, often teaching subjects in which they have no background. This problem becomes even more severe in Grades 6-8
- Very rarely are teachers appointed to subjects/areas that have been traditionally given the status of "co-curricular", e.g. music, sports, arts.
- Physical resources such as experimental kits, laboratory equipment, library books etc., are very inadequate across schools.

Second, small schools present a systemic challenge for governance and management. The geographical dispersion, challenging access conditions and the very large numbers of schools, make it difficult for any effort to reach all schools equally. This has an impact on improvement initiatives, on provision of support that the schools need (e.g. BRC and DIET), and all matters of interface of the individual school with the overall education system. This situation is exacerbated because the administrative structures have not been expanded in accordance with the expansion of the number of schools.

Restructuring government schools in Karnataka

Study of small schools and feasibility of school consolidation in Karnataka



Akshara
Foundation

EVERY CHILD IN SCHOOL AND LEARNING WELL

Dr. Shivakumar Jolad, Assistant Professor, Indian Institute of Technology, Gandhinagar
Mrs. K. Vaijayanti, Head, Research, Resource and Evaluation
Akshara Foundation, Bengaluru

Restructuring India's schooling system, Ideas for India, May , 2018
India needs to restructure its school

State of Inclusive Growth in India: Some Perspectives

Rama Mohana R. Turaga, Manali Chakrabarti, Mirai Chatterjee, **Shivakumar Jolad, Vaijayanti K., M. S. Sriram;**
Vikalpa, 43(1), 2018



Restructuring government schools in Karnataka

Study of small schools and feasibility of school consolidation in Karnataka

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SMALL SCHOOLS- BENGALURU RURAL

GLPS, Paramanahalli



2016-17

Class	Enrollment
1	3
2	2
3	0
4	0
5	2
6	0
7	0
Total	7

GLPS, Hunasehalli



Grade	2014-15	2015-16		
	All	All	Boys	Girls
I	5	5	3	2
II	2	5	2	3
III	1	2	1	1
IV	4	2	1	1
V	1	5	3	2
VI	0	0	0	0
VII	0	0	0	0
VIII	0	0	0	0
Total	13	19	10	9

Total teachers : 1

EMPTYING OF GOVERNMENT SCHOOLS



**Government Higher Primary School-
Vagata
Bengaluru Rural**

GHPS Vagata

Grade	2014-15	2015-16	2016-17
1	10	6	6
2	9	9	8
3	10	8	8
4	16	9	11
5	14	15	10
6	35	29	26
7	40	34	27
Total	134	110	96

Currently **82** students on roll-

On the day of visit- head count **60**

Out of the 96 students on roll, 24 are SC, 24 are Muslim children (50%)

SCHOOLS IN SHIVAJINAGAR, BENGALURU URBAN

GULPS MAKHAN ROAD



Enrolment & Repeaters

Grade	2014-15	2015-16
	All	All
I	3	5
II	3	4
III	1	3
IV	2	1
V	0	0
VI	0	0
VII	0	0
VIII	0	0
Total	9	13

GULPS RAHAMANIA



Grade	2014-15	2015-16
	All	All
I	5	6
II	8	5
III	6	12
IV	12	5
V	8	9
VI	13	9
VII	7	10
VIII	0	0
Total	59	56

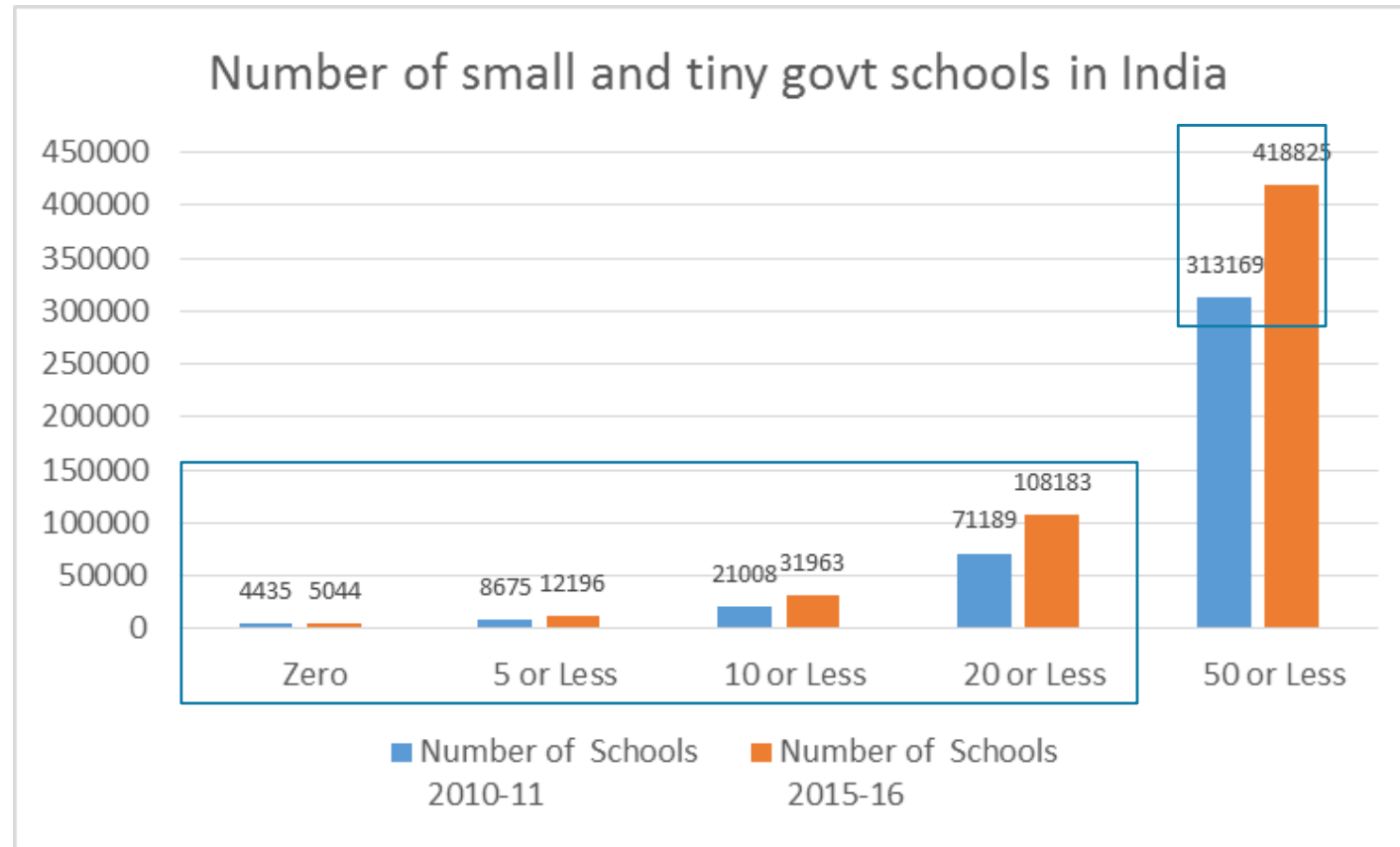
CORP URD HPS, NARAYANPILLE STREET



Enrolment & Repeaters

Grade	2014-15	Total		
	All	All	Boys	Girls
I	22	22	11	11
II	24	23	9	14
III	21	23	11	12
IV	30	23	14	9
V	23	24	9	15
VI	28	22	9	13
VII	27	29	13	16
VIII	0	0	0	0
Total	175	166	76	90

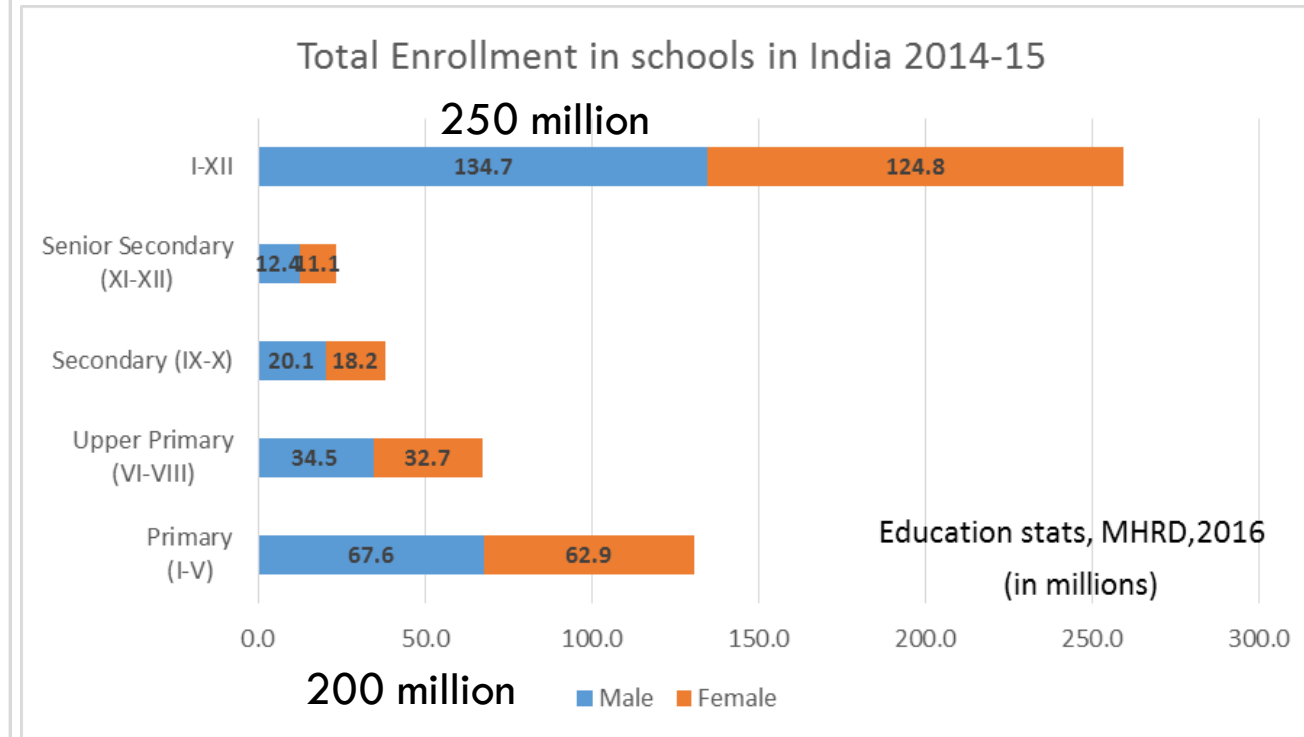
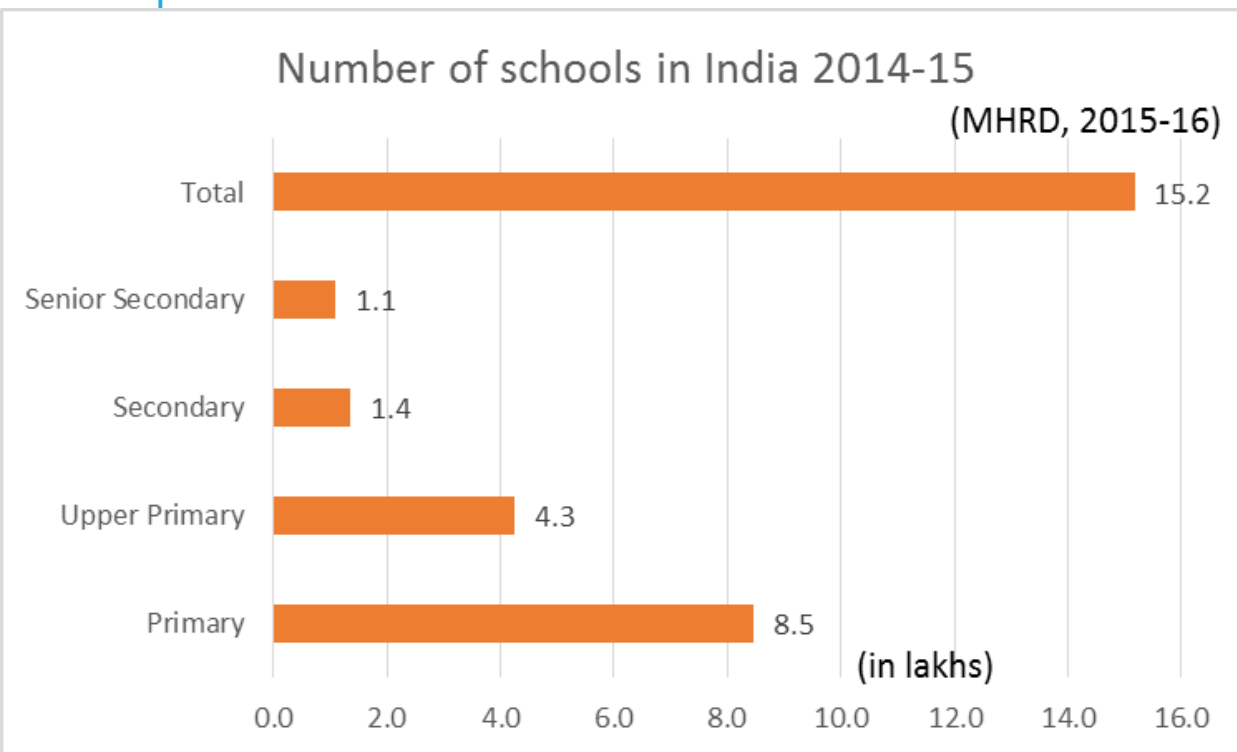
SMALL AND TINY GOVERNMENT SCHOOLS



Total government schools 1.1 million

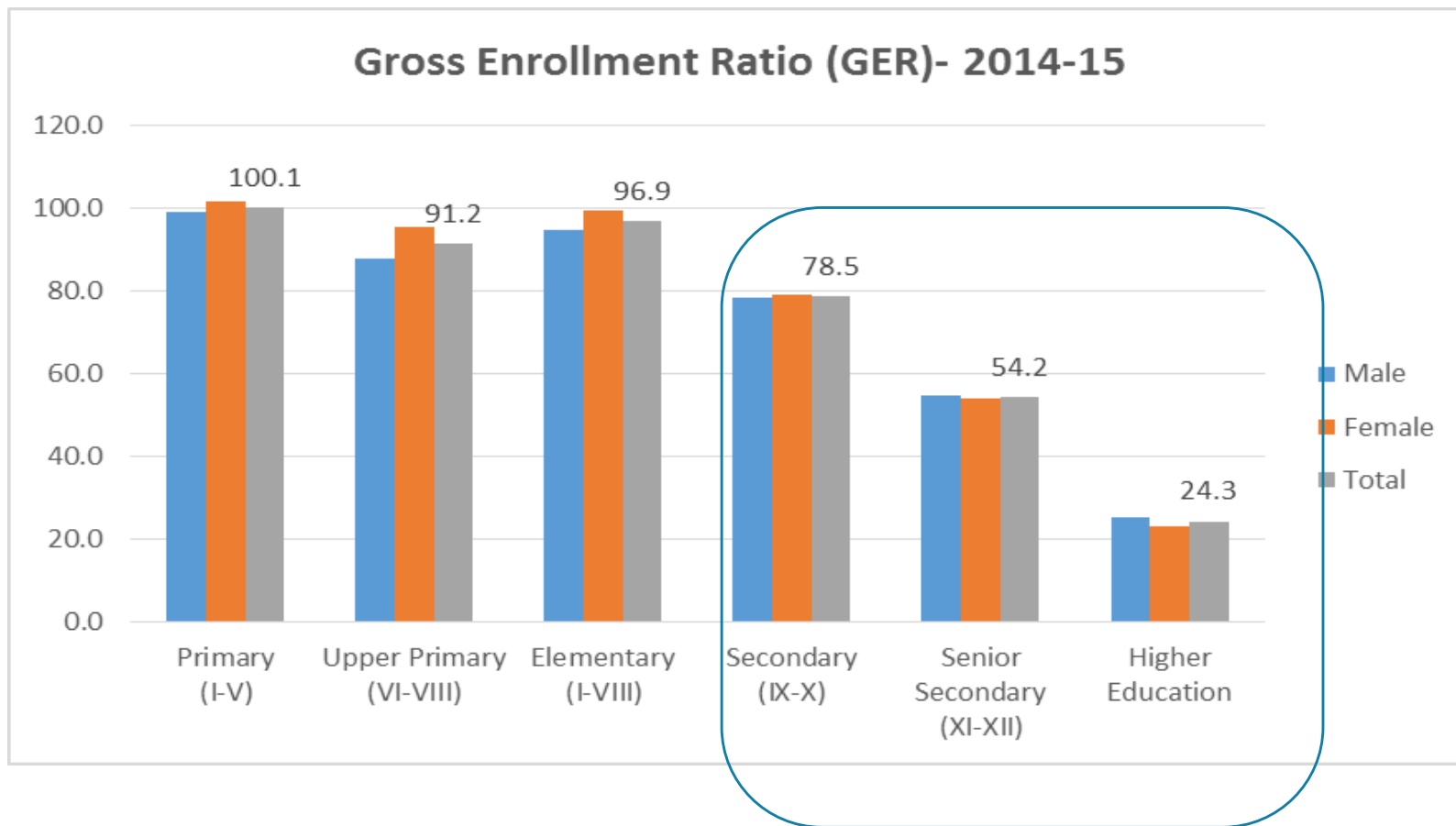
Almost 50% of the government schools have enrollment 50 or less

SCHOOL PROFILE OF INDIA

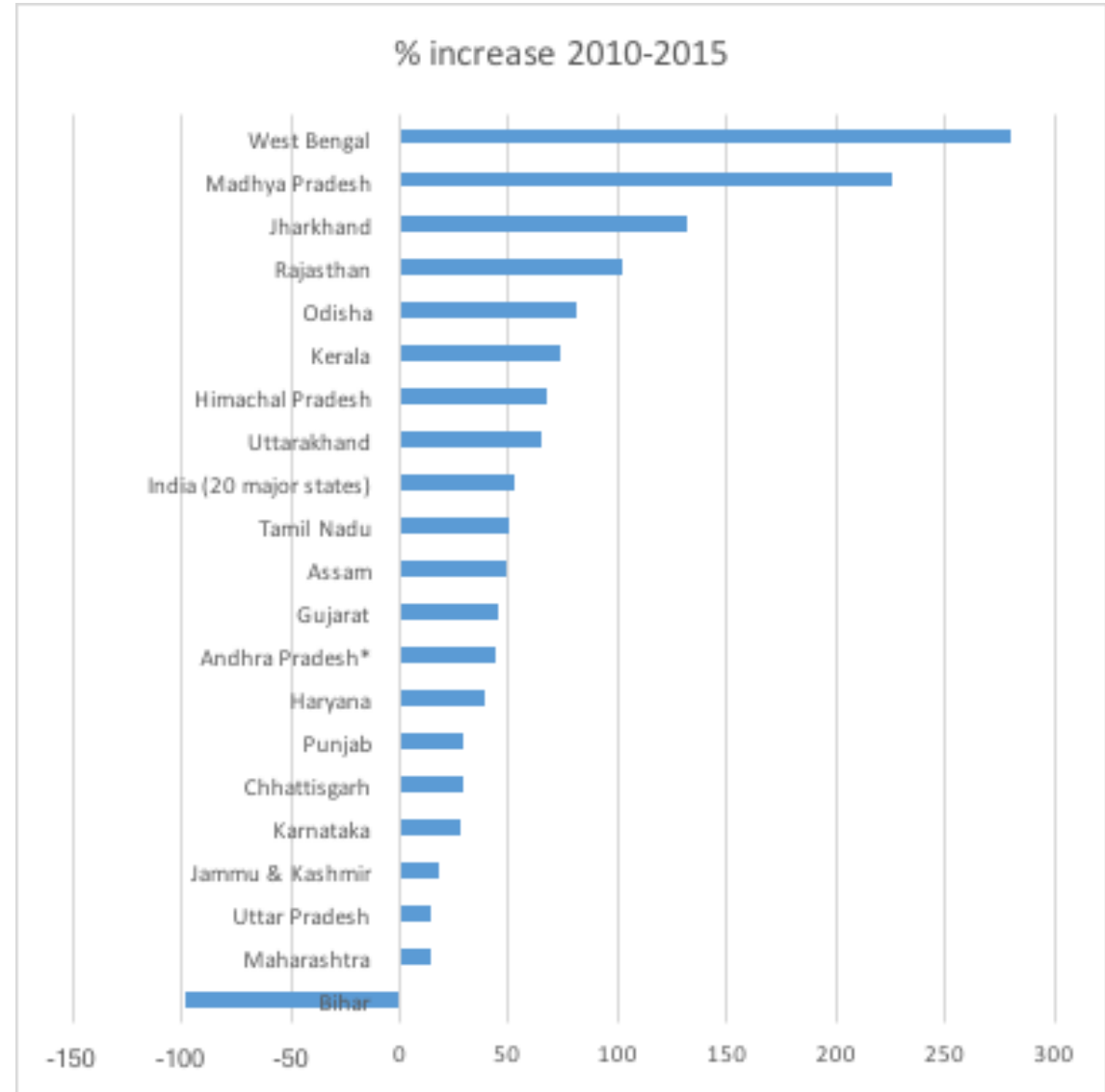
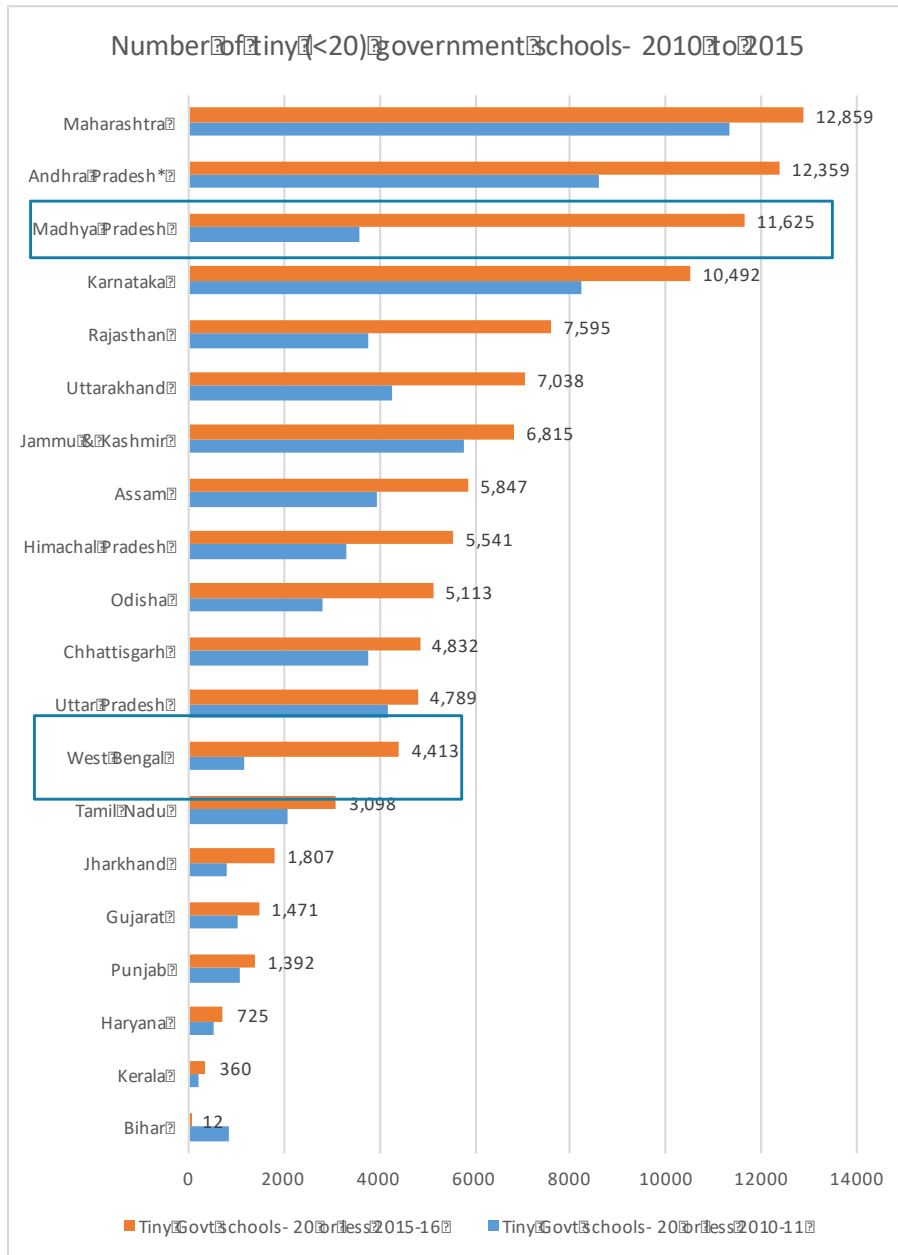


Based on District Information System on Education (DISE)
2014-15 data and compilation by MHRD

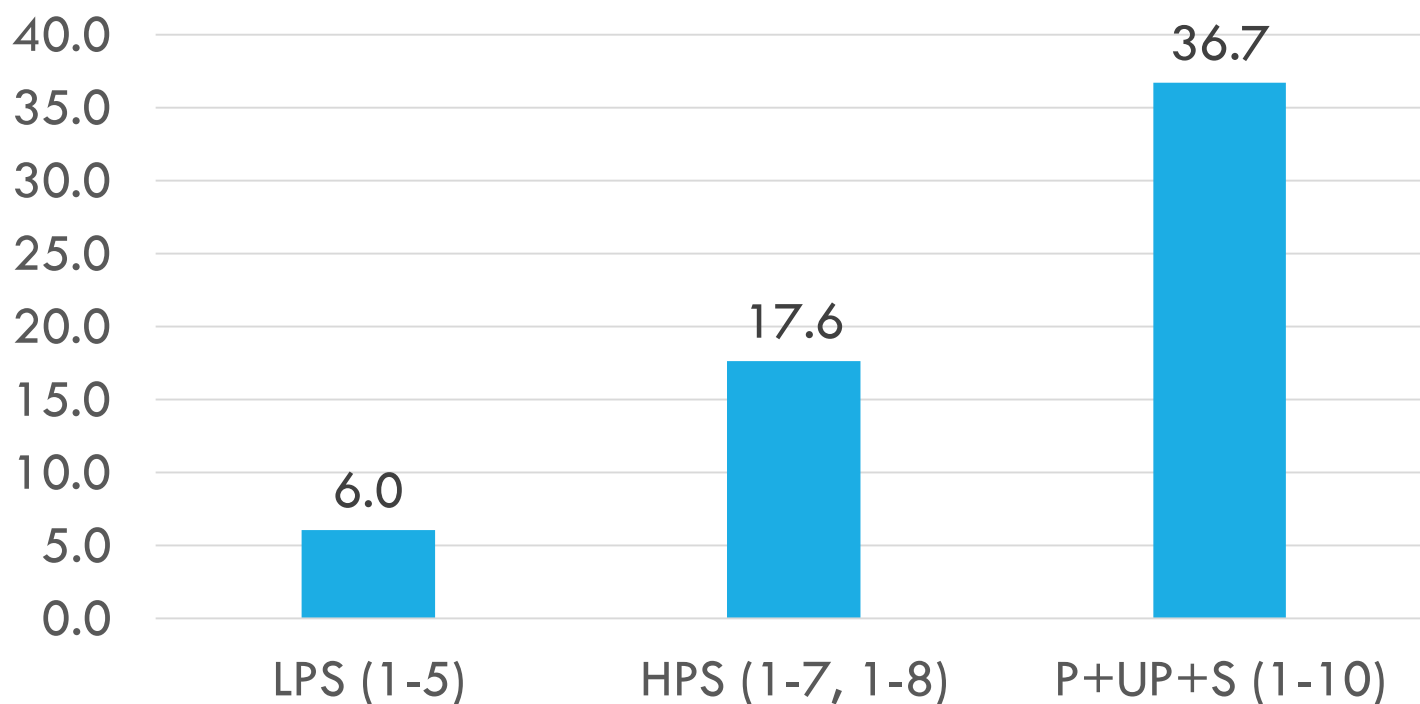
GER



INTERSTATE VARIATIONS- TINY SCHOOLS

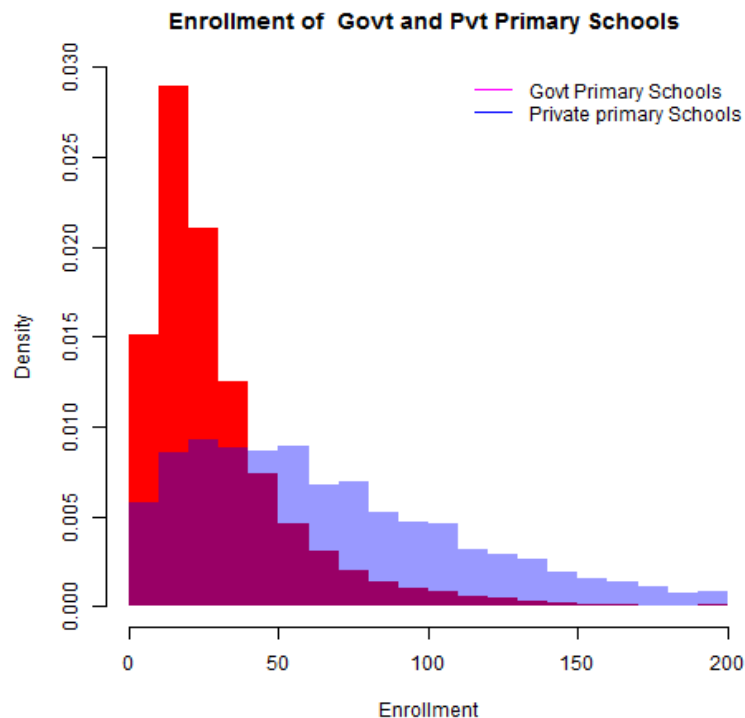


Karnataka Government Schools
Per Class Enrollment
(DISE 2015-16 data)



Need for continuity of schooling from Primary, Upper primary and secondary

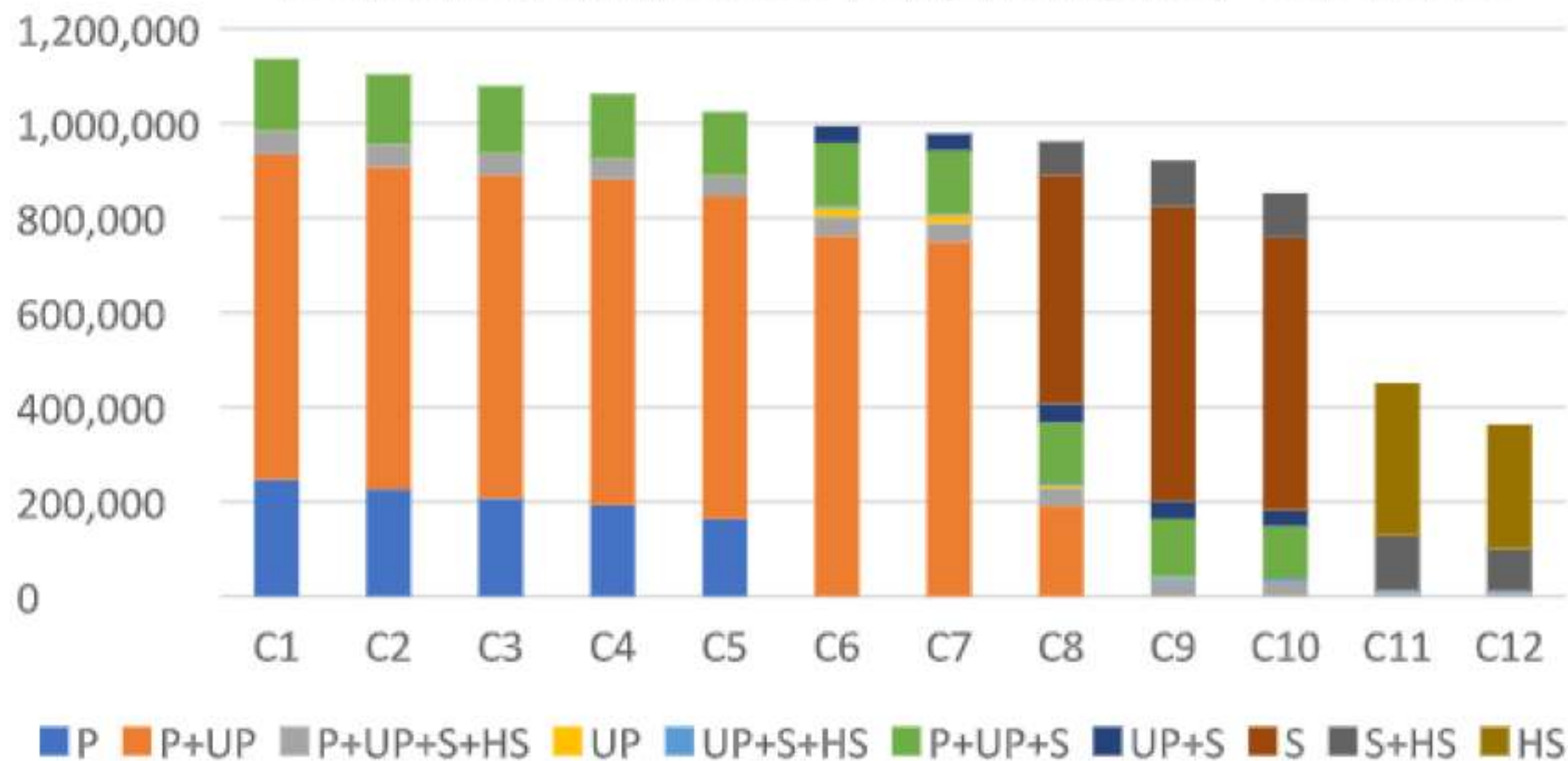
KARNATAKA PRIMARY SCHOOL SIZE DISTRIBUTION (LPS, CL: 1-5)



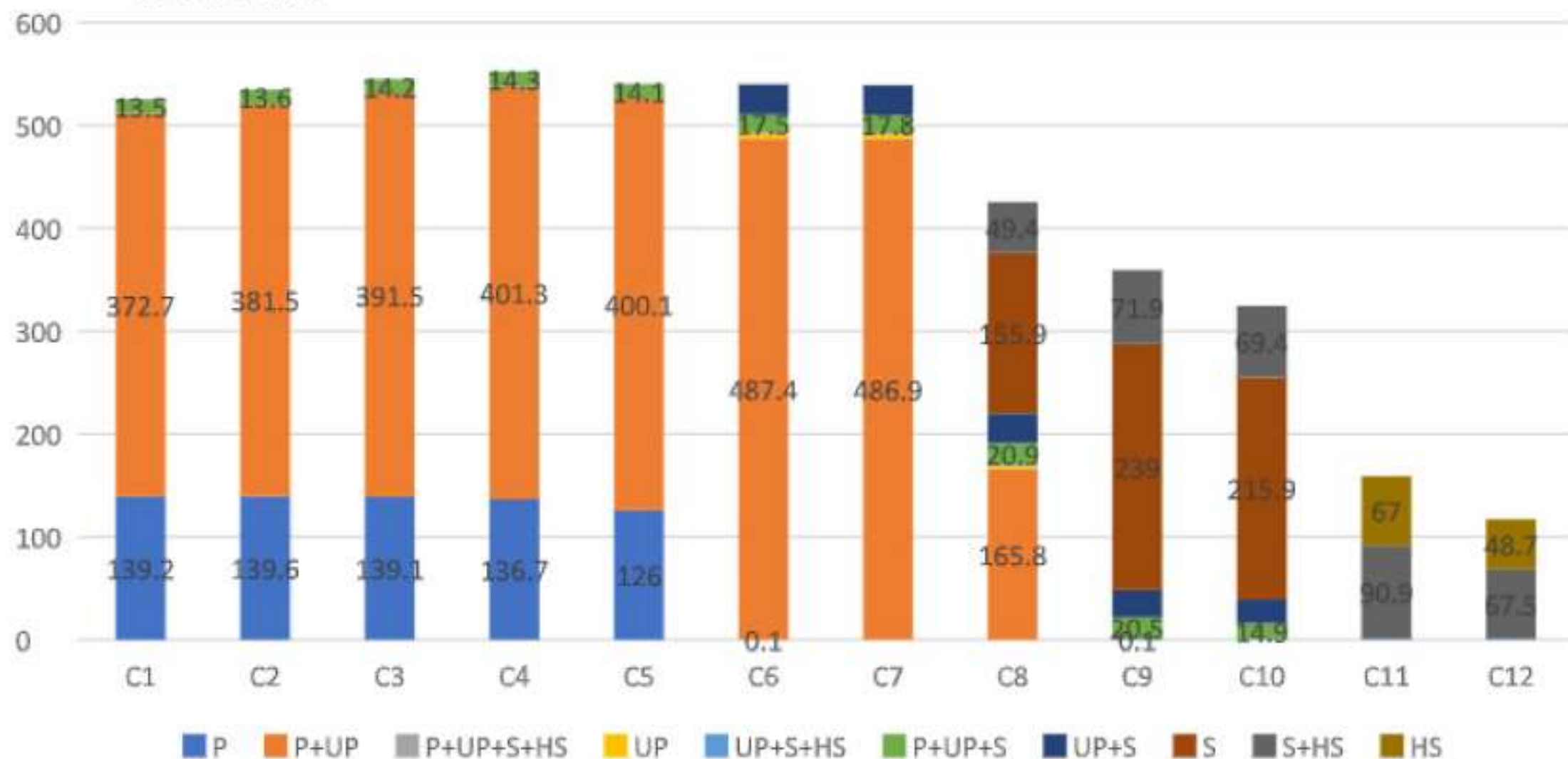
Karnataka	Distribution of Government Primary Schools (LPS) in Karnataka					
Enrollment bins	(0,25]	(25,50]	(50,100]	(100,150]	(150,200]	(200,3000]
Schools	11799	6630	2701	542	93	20
Schools (%)	54.2	30.4	12.4	2.5	0.4	0.1
Cumulative Schools (%)	54.2	84.6	97.0	99.5	99.9	100.0
Total Enrollment	178155	233539	183508	64415	15866	5250
Enrollment (%)	26.2	34.3	27.0	9.5	2.3	0.8
Cumulative Enrollment (%)	26.2	60.5	87.4	96.9	99.2	100.0
Mean Enrollment	15.1	35.2	67.9	118.8	170.6	262.5
Median Enrollment	15	34	65	116	167	256

- 54% of K-Government schools have enrollment less than 25 - i.e. per class enrollment is less than 5
- 85% of schools have enrollment less than 50 i.e. Less than 10 Children per class

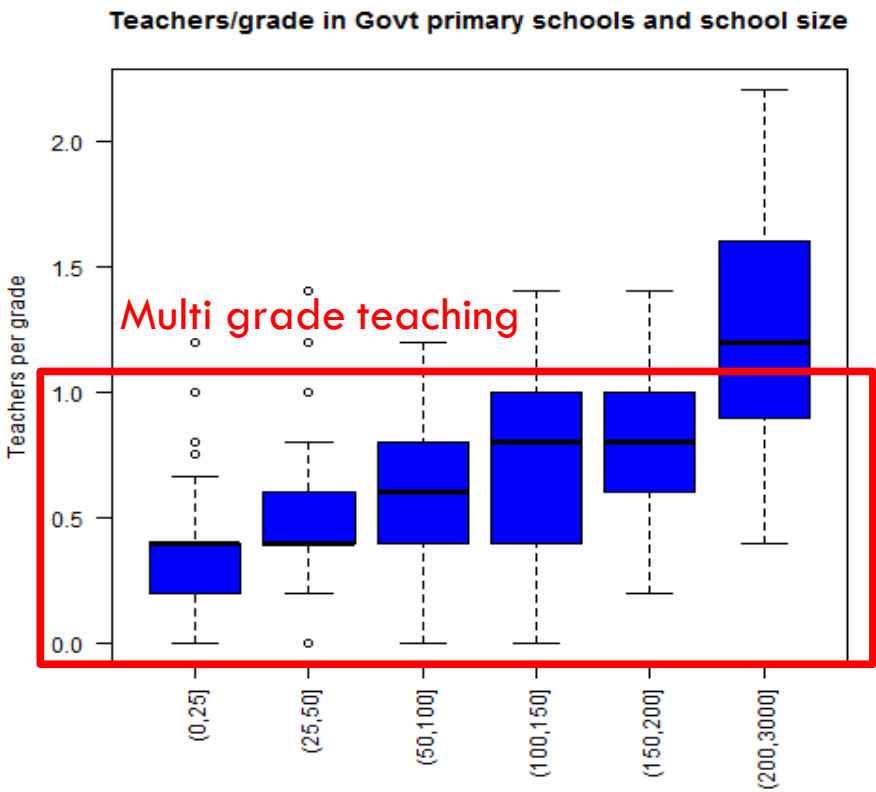
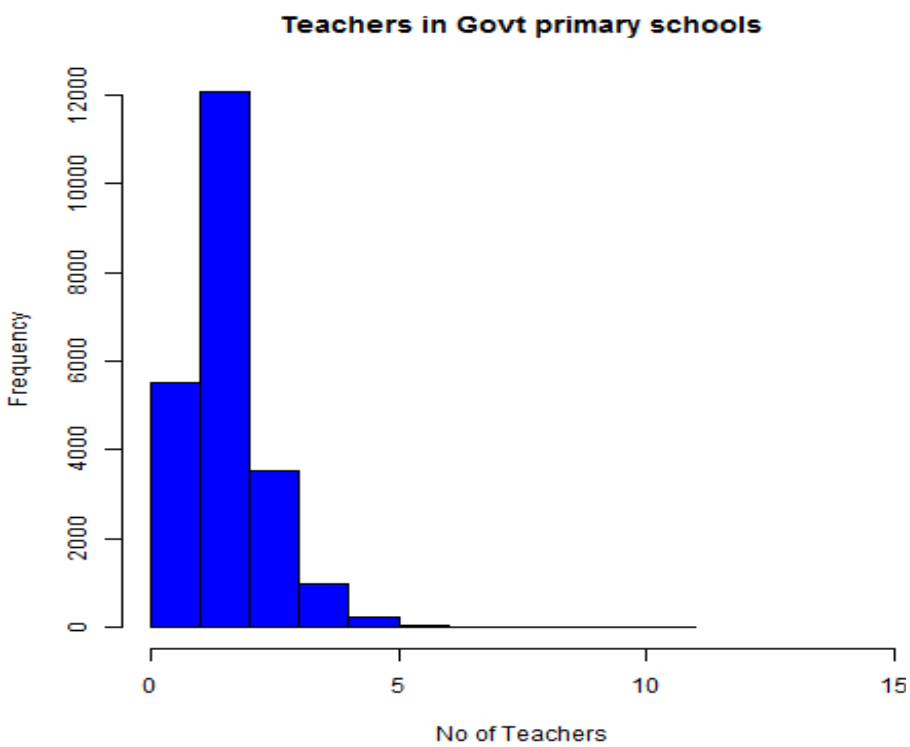
Karnataka Enrolment classes 1-12 (All Categories) - DISE 2015-16



Class wise enrolment (in thousands) in Government Schools in Karnataka



TEACHER DISTRIBUTION- GOVERNMENT LPS (CLASS: 1-5)

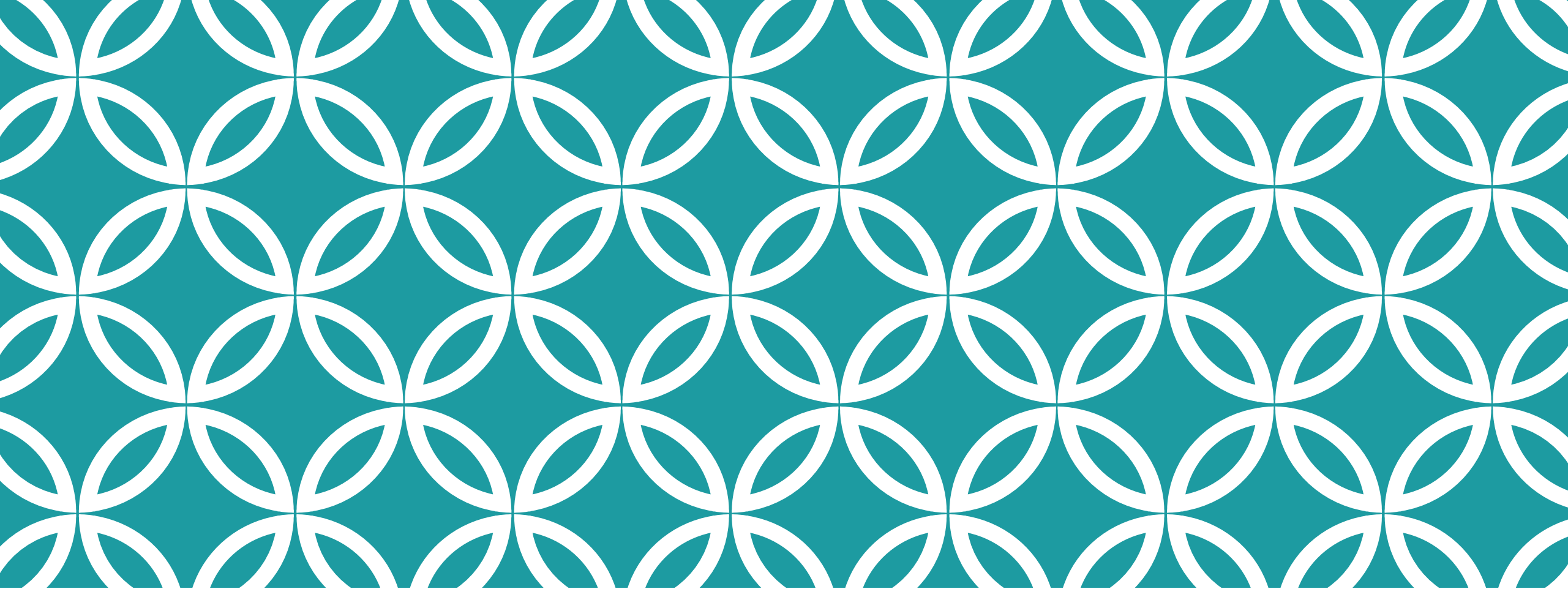


Median
2.000

Mean
1.996

Max.
11.000

Teachers per grade in government primary schools by Enrollment Category						
Enrollment bin	(0,25]	(25,50]	(50,100]	(100,150]	(150,200]	(200,3000]
Median	0.4	0.4	0.6	0.8	0.8	1.2
Mean	0.34	0.43	0.56	0.70	0.80	1.23



COMPARATIVE EDUCATION SYSTEM



INTRODUCTION TO SCHOOL EDUCATION IN SOUTH ASIA

South Asia is home to 1.5 billion people, making it one of the densest regions in the world.

Covers Afghanistan, Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, Maldives, Nepal, Pakistan, Sri Lanka, Mauritius, and Myanmar.

Common characteristics: colonial legacy, diverse ethnic & linguistic backgrounds, and international policy influences.

Significant socioeconomic inequalities impact education policies and access.

EDUCATION TRENDS & INTERNATIONAL COMMITMENTS

- South Asian countries signed treaties like the Convention on Rights of the Child (CRC), committing to universal education.
- Participated in Education for All (EFA) (1990), Millennium Development Goals (MDGs) (2000), and Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) (2015).
- Primary education enrollment improved: from 75% in 2000 to 89% in 2010.
- Despite progress, gender disparities and rural-urban gaps persist.

COLONIAL LEGACY & EDUCATION POLICIES

Education in India, Pakistan, Bangladesh, and Sri Lanka was shaped by British rule.

Colonial policies focused on creating an elite administrative workforce rather than mass education.

Free and compulsory education existed at provincial levels but was largely unimplemented.

Post-independence, national governments retained British education structures while expanding access.

SCHOOL ENROLLMENT & EQUITY CHALLENGES

Afghanistan and Pakistan still struggle with universal school access due to conflict, poverty, and cultural barriers.

Bhutan and Nepal have achieved near gender parity in school enrollments.

Disadvantaged groups: Indigenous children, street children, and migrants remain excluded from education systems.

Private schooling is growing but remains inaccessible for lower-income groups.

SCHOOL TYPES & LANGUAGE POLICIES

- **Diverse schooling models:** Public schools, private schools, religious schools (Madrasas), and international schools.
- **Bangladesh** has **25 different school types**, highlighting fragmentation.
- **Language challenges:**
 - **Pakistan:** Urdu is used as an instructional language, though it is not the first language of most students.
 - **Myanmar:** Despite linguistic diversity, Burmese dominates school instruction.
 - **India & Bangladesh:** Growing demand for **English-medium schools**.

QUALITY OF EDUCATION & TEACHER CHALLENGES

- **Teacher shortages** in countries like **Afghanistan, Maldives, and Sri Lanka**.
- **Unqualified or temporary teachers** hired in many regions to meet demand.
- Poor teacher training leads to **low learning outcomes** across South Asia.
- **International assessments show learning gaps**, with **many children failing basic literacy and numeracy skills**.

EXAMINATIONS, DECENTRALIZATION & FINANCE

- **Examination reforms:**

- Nepal introduced **letter grading** instead of marks, but student performance remains low.
- India attempted **Continuous and Comprehensive Evaluation (CCE)** but later revised it.

- **Decentralization efforts:**

- Nepal's education system is shifting to local governance, but implementation is slow.
- Pakistan and Bangladesh have **education financing gaps** due to weak provincial funding.

- **Low public spending:** Most South Asian countries **fail to meet the global benchmark of 4–6% of GDP on education.**

ROLE OF INTERNATIONAL AID & FUTURE CHALLENGES

Key Points:

- **Foreign aid has shaped education policies** in Nepal, Afghanistan, and Sri Lanka.
- **New Public Management (NPM) models** have influenced governance approaches.
- **Growing privatization raises concerns about equity and access.**
- **Emerging Issues:**
 - Balancing **national vs. international policy influences.**
 - Improving **teacher quality & curriculum relevance.**
 - Addressing **disparities between urban and rural schooling.**